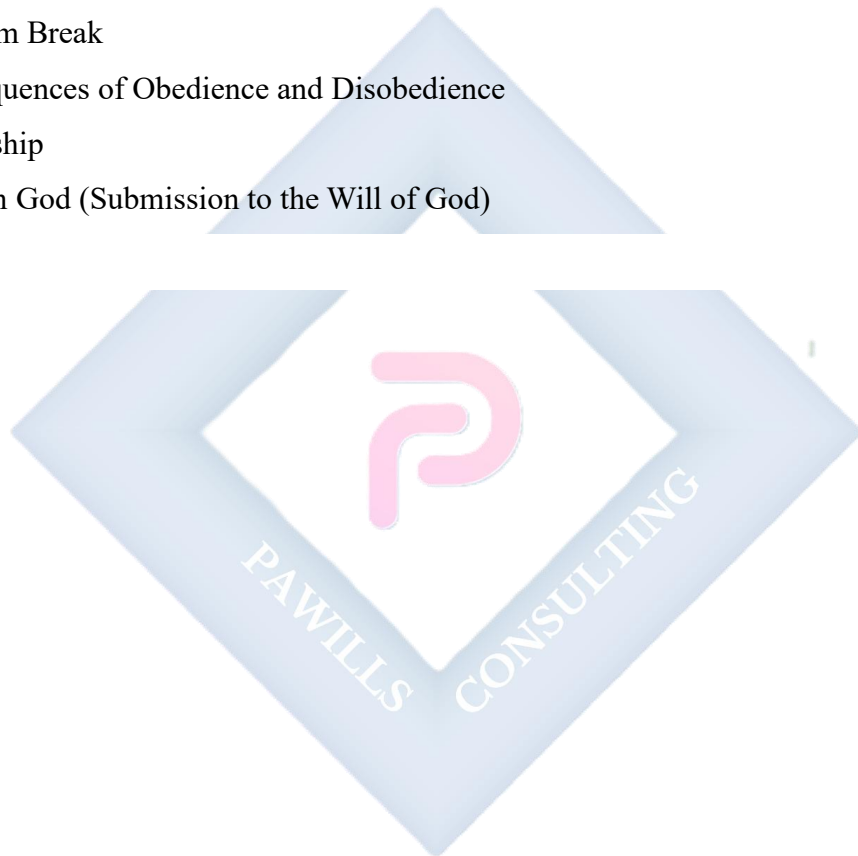


SS2 CHRISTIAN RELIGIOUS STUDIES

FIRST TERM

1. Leadership of Joseph, Moses, Joshua and Deborah I
2. Leadership of Joseph, Moses, Joshua and Deborah II
3. Leadership of Joseph, Moses, Joshua and Deborah III
4. God Cares for His People – Protection
5. Midterm Examination
6. Parental Responsibility (Eli and His Sons)
7. Midterm Break
8. Consequences of Obedience and Disobedience
9. Friendship
10. Trust In God (Submission to the Will of God)



WEEK 1: THE LEADERSHIP OF JOSEPH - FROM THE PIT TO THE PALACE

Introduction: The Concept of Leadership Leadership is the ability to guide, direct, influence, and inspire a group of people towards achieving a common goal. It involves a set of skills and character traits that enable an individual to mobilize and manage others effectively. This week, we begin our study by examining Joseph, a leader whose journey was defined by resilience, integrity, and divine purpose.

Joseph's Early Life and Trials (Genesis 37) Joseph was the eleventh son of Jacob, born to Rachel, Jacob's beloved wife. His father's obvious favoritism, symbolized by the gift of a "richly ornamented robe" (often called a "coat of many colors"), bred deep resentment among his brothers. This jealousy was compounded by Joseph's dreams, which prophetically indicated that his family would one day bow down to him. Instead of keeping these dreams to himself, Joseph shared them, further inflaming his brothers' hatred.

Their bitterness led them to conspire against him. Initially planning to kill him, they instead sold him as a slave to a caravan of Ishmaelite traders for twenty shekels of silver. The brothers then deceived their father into believing Joseph had been killed by a wild animal.

Leadership Forged in Adversity (Genesis 39-41) In Egypt, Joseph was sold to Potiphar, the captain of Pharaoh's guard. Despite his circumstances, Joseph's integrity and competence shone through, and he was put in charge of Potiphar's entire household. When he resisted the advances of Potiphar's wife, he was falsely accused of assault and thrown into prison.

Even in prison, Joseph's leadership qualities persisted. He earned the trust of the prison warden and was given responsibility over other prisoners. His God-given ability to interpret dreams for Pharaoh's chief cupbearer and chief baker eventually became his path to freedom. When Pharaoh was troubled by his own dreams, the restored cupbearer remembered Joseph.

Joseph interpreted Pharaoh's dreams, revealing that seven years of abundance would be followed by seven years of severe famine. He then proposed a strategic plan: appoint a discerning leader to store surplus grain during the plentiful years to prepare for the famine.

Joseph the National Leader (Genesis 41:37-57) Impressed by his wisdom and the spirit of God within him, Pharaoh appointed Joseph as vizier, second-in-command over all of Egypt. Joseph executed his plan with exceptional administrative skill, overseeing the massive storage and subsequent distribution of grain. His leadership not only saved Egypt but also surrounding nations, including his own family, who came to buy food.

Major Leadership Qualities of Joseph

1. **Resilience and Perseverance:** He maintained his faith and integrity through betrayal, slavery, and imprisonment.
2. **Integrity and Moral Courage:** He refused to sin against God and his master, Potiphar, even when it cost him his freedom.
3. **Divine Wisdom and Discernment:** He possessed the spiritual gift of dream interpretation and the practical wisdom to formulate a complex national survival plan.
4. **Administrative Excellence:** He was a highly effective manager, entrusted with Potiphar's estate, the prison, and ultimately, the entire nation of Egypt.
5. **Forgiveness and Grace:** He saw God's greater purpose in his suffering and forgave his brothers completely, stating, "You intended to harm me, but God intended it for good to accomplish what is now being done" (Genesis 50:20).

Lessons to Learn

- **God's Sovereignty:** God can turn any situation, no matter how dire, for a greater good for those who trust in Him.
- **Integrity in Secret:** True character is revealed when no one is watching. Joseph's faithfulness in private prepared him for public leadership.
- **The Power of Forgiveness:** Holding onto bitterness hinders destiny. Forgiveness is a key trait of a great leader.

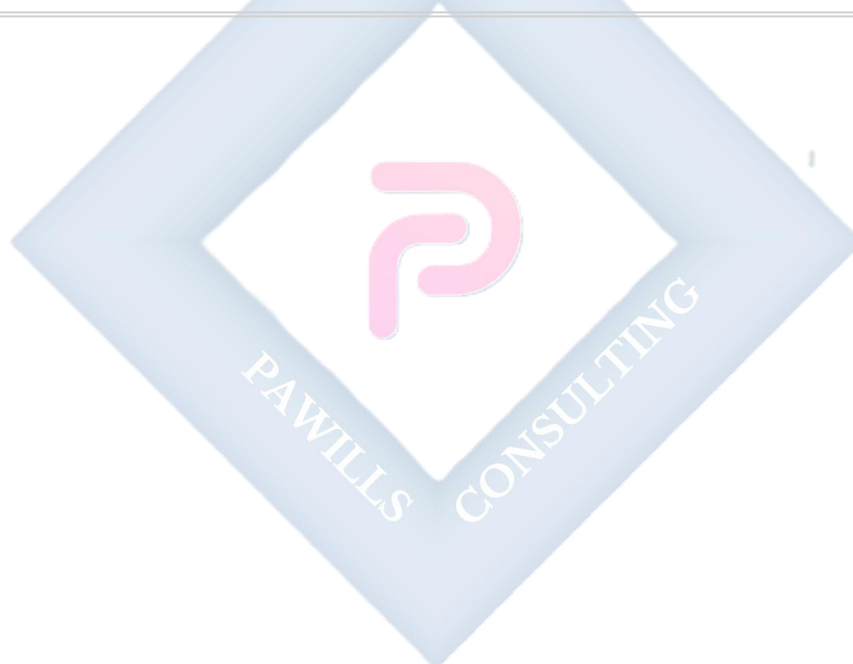
WEEK 1 EVALUATION

1. Describe two key events from Joseph's early life that prepared him for future leadership.

2. What was the significance of Joseph's interpretation of Pharaoh's dreams for the nation of Egypt?
3. List three leadership qualities demonstrated by Joseph and provide an example of each from his story.

WEEK 1 ASSIGNMENT

1. Write a short essay (250 words) on the topic: "How Joseph's adversity in Potiphar's house and prison was a training ground for his leadership in the palace."
2. In today's world, how can the principle of "forgiving those who wrong you," as demonstrated by Joseph, be applied to resolve conflicts in a school or community? Provide a practical example.



WEEK 2: THE LEADERSHIP OF MOSES - THE RELUCTANT LIBERATOR

Introduction: A Leader Shaped by Destiny Moses' story is one of divine calling, immense responsibility, and the challenge of leading a stubborn people. His leadership was not sought but was bestowed upon him by God for a specific, redemptive purpose.

The Birth, Flight, and Call of Moses (Exodus 1-4) After Joseph's death, a new Pharaoh arose who enslaved the Israelites. To control their population, he ordered all newborn Hebrew boys to be killed. Moses was saved by his mother and Pharaoh's own daughter, who adopted him. Raised in the Egyptian palace, Moses retained a connection to his people. After killing an Egyptian taskmaster for beating a Hebrew, he fled to Midian.

There, God called him through a burning bush at Mount Horeb, commissioning him to lead the Israelites out of Egypt. Moses was reluctant, offering excuses: "Who am I?"; "What if they do not believe me?"; "I am slow of speech and tongue." God patiently addressed each objection, providing signs, promising His presence, and appointing his brother Aaron as a spokesman.

Leading the Exodus and Confronting Pharaoh (Exodus 5-14) Moses and Aaron confronted Pharaoh with God's demand: "Let my people go." Pharaoh's refusal led to ten devastating plagues, demonstrating God's power over the Egyptian gods. Throughout this process, Moses acted as God's intermediary, showing obedience and courage.

The climax was the Passover and the crossing of the Red Sea. When the Israelites were trapped between the sea and Pharaoh's army, Moses, trusting God, stretched out his staff. God parted the sea, allowing Israel to cross on dry ground, then drowned the pursuing Egyptian army. This event cemented Moses' role as God's chosen leader.

Challenges of Leading the Israelites (Exodus 16-17, 32; Numbers 13-14) Moses' leadership was constantly tested:

- **Murmuring and Complaints:** The people frequently grumbled about food and water, longing for Egypt.

- **The Golden Calf:** While Moses was on Mount Sinai receiving the Law, the people persuaded Aaron to build an idol. Moses interceded for them, begging God not to destroy them.
- **The Twelve Spies:** When ten of the twelve spies sent to Canaan brought back a fearful report, the people rebelled. Again, Moses interceded, pleading for God's mercy. This rebellion resulted in 40 years of wandering in the wilderness.

Moses' Qualities as a Leader

1. **Intercessory Heart:** He consistently prayed for the people, even when God offered to make a nation from him alone.
2. **Obedience to God:** He followed divine instructions meticulously, even when they seemed strange.
3. **Courage and Resilience:** He stood before Pharaoh and managed the constant complaints and rebellions of the Israelites.
4. **Humility:** He is described as "a very humble man, more humble than anyone else on the face of the earth" (Numbers 12:3).
5. **Patriotism and Selflessness:** He identified with his people and sacrificed his own comfort and potential privilege for their sake.

Lessons to Learn

- **Effective leadership requires a deep prayer life and a heart for the people you lead.**
- **Obedience to God is non-negotiable for success in divine assignments.**
- **Leadership is often a lonely and difficult task that demands patience and resilience.**

WEEK 2 EVALUATION

1. Explain two excuses Moses gave at his call and how God addressed them.
2. Describe one major crisis Moses faced in the wilderness and how he resolved it.
3. Why is Moses described as a selfless leader? Provide evidence from the scripture.

WEEK 2 ASSIGNMENT

1. Compare and contrast the leadership challenges Joseph and Moses faced. Which leader, in your opinion, faced a more difficult task? Justify your answer.
 2. Moses was a great intercessor. As a student leader, how can you apply the principle of intercession (standing in the gap for others) to resolve a conflict within your class or peer group?
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WEEK 3: THE LEADERSHIP OF JOSHUA AND DEBORAH - COURAGE AND CONVICTION

Introduction: Diverse Models of Effective Leadership This week, we study two contrasting but equally effective leaders: Joshua, the courageous military successor, and Deborah, the wise prophetess and judge. They show that godly leadership is not confined to one gender or style.

Part A: Joshua as a Leader

From Assistant to Leader (Numbers 13-14; 27:15-23; Joshua 1) Joshua first appears as Moses' assistant. He was one of the twelve spies sent into Canaan. While ten spies gave a fear-based report, Joshua and Caleb confidently urged the people to take the land, trusting in God's promise. This faith marked him as a man with a different spirit.

When Moses was about to die, God instructed him to commission Joshua as his successor. Moses laid his hands on Joshua, imparting wisdom and authority to him. God's charge to Joshua was clear: "Be strong and courageous... Be careful to obey all the law my servant Moses gave you; do not turn from it to the right or to the left, and you will be successful wherever you go" (Joshua 1:7).

The Conquest of Jericho (Joshua 6) Joshua's leadership was immediately tested at Jericho. Instead of a conventional military strategy, God gave him a divine plan: to march around the city for seven days. Joshua's faith and obedience were absolute. He followed the strange instructions precisely, and the walls of Jericho collapsed, leading to a stunning victory.

Joshua's Success and Final Charge (Joshua 24) Joshua led Israel in conquering the Promised Land. In his old age, he gathered the people and, like a true leader, challenged them to recommit to God, famously declaring, "But as for me and my household, we will serve the Lord" (Joshua 24:15).

Why Joshua Succeeded

- **Faith and Courage:** He believed God's promises against all odds.
- **Obedience:** He followed God's instructions without question.
- **Preparation:** He served faithfully under Moses for years.

Part B: Deborah as a Leader

A Mother in Israel (Judges 4) After Joshua's death, Israel was ruled by judges. Deborah was a prophetess and the only female judge. She held court under a palm tree, and people came to her for judgment. This alone signifies her immense wisdom and the respect she commanded.

A Liberator in Battle When Israel was oppressed by King Jabin of Canaan, Deborah received a word from God. She summoned Barak, a military commander, and told him God's command to go to battle. Barak's response, "If you go with me, I will go; but if you don't go with me, I won't go," reveals his reliance on her spiritual authority and courage.

Deborah agreed to go but prophesied that the honor of victory would go to a woman. She accompanied Barak, and Israel won a great victory. The enemy commander, Sisera, was indeed killed by a woman, Jael, fulfilling Deborah's prophecy.

Leadership Qualities of Deborah

1. **Wisdom and Discernment:** She was a trusted judge and prophetess.
2. **Courage and Initiative:** She did not hesitate to go to the battlefield.
3. **Collaboration:** She worked with Barak, empowering him to fulfill his role.
4. **Inspirational Authority:** Her presence inspired confidence in the military leader.

Lessons to Learn from Joshua and Deborah

- **Faith is the foundation for overcoming great obstacles.**
- **Obedience to God, even when His ways seem illogical, leads to victory.**
- **God can use anyone—regardless of gender—who is willing, faithful, and courageous.**
- **True leadership is about empowering others to succeed.**

WEEK 3 EVALUATION

1. What two qualities did Joshua demonstrate in the story of the twelve spies that made him fit to succeed Moses?
2. Describe the unconventional strategy God gave to Joshua for the battle of Jericho. What does this reveal about the nature of godly leadership?

3. Barak insisted that Deborah go with him to the battle. What does this tell you about Deborah's leadership?

WEEK 3 ASSIGNMENT

1. Deborah's story breaks cultural stereotypes about leadership. In a well-structured essay, argue for or against the statement: "The most important quality for a leader is not their gender, but their character, competence, and courage." Use Deborah and one other leader from this term as examples.
2. Joshua's key to success was meditating on and obeying God's law. As a student, what "law" or principles (e.g., discipline, hard work, integrity) do you need to meditate on and obey to be successful in your studies? Create a personal plan of action.



WEEK 4: GOD'S TANGIBLE CARE - GUIDANCE, PROTECTION, AND PROVISION

THEME: Encountering God's Faithfulness in Our Deepest Needs

A. DIVINE GUIDANCE: From Panic to Promise at the Red Sea (Exodus 14)

- **The Anatomy of a Crisis:** The Israelites' journey from slavery to freedom hit an impossible barrier: the Egyptian army behind them and the Red Sea ahead. This moment reveals a common human response: when God's path leads to a dead end, we panic. Their accusatory questions to Moses—"Was it because there were no graves in Egypt...?"—expose a faith based on immediate circumstance rather than on God's proven character. This is the "crisis of the in-between," where the past is gone but the future seems inaccessible.
- **The Theology of "Stand Firm":** Moses' command, "**Do not be afraid. Stand firm, and see the salvation of the Lord**" (Exodus 14:13), is a foundational principle. "Standing firm" is not passive waiting; it is an active posture of trust that halts the instinct to flee or revert to old patterns (like wanting to return to Egypt). It is the decision to let God fight the battle His way. The subsequent command to "**move on**" (Exodus 14:15) shows that God's guidance often comes as a partnership: we trust, and then we obey the specific, sometimes illogical, next step (like marching into a sea).
- **The Miracle as a Covenant Act:** The parted sea was more than a spectacle; it was a cosmic judgment on the gods of Egypt (the sea, chaos) and a salvation-historical event that baptized a nation into a new identity. The "wall of water" on either side symbolized both judgment and salvation, a theme that culminates in Christian baptism (1 Corinthians 10:1-2). This event was meant to cement their trust in both God and His prophet, Moses.

B. THE MULTIFACETED GUIDANCE OF GOD FOR BELIEVERS TODAY

God's guidance system is holistic, designed to shape our character as much as our direction.

1. **The Person of Christ (The Good Shepherd):** Jesus is not merely a model; He is the active guide. To be guided is to be in a relational, listening relationship with Him. **"My sheep listen to my voice; I know them, and they follow me"** (John 10:27).
2. **The Inner Witness of the Holy Spirit (The Compass):** The Spirit provides inner conviction, peace (Colossians 3:15), and a sense of restraint or prompting (Acts 16:6-7). This guidance is always congruent with the character of God revealed in Scripture.
3. **The Authority of Scripture (The Map):** The Bible provides the non-negotiable moral and spiritual boundaries. God will never lead us to do something that contradicts His written Word. It is the primary tool for testing all other guidance.
4. **The Wisdom of Godly Community (The Trail Markers):** God places people in our lives—pastors, mentors, mature friends—to provide perspective, wisdom, and accountability (Proverbs 15:22).
5. **The Sovereignty of Circumstances (The Landscape):** God can open and close doors, but circumstances are the least reliable guide on their own and must be interpreted through the lens of Scripture, prayer, and godly counsel.

C. DIVINE PROTECTION: The Integrity of Daniel in the Lions' Den (Daniel 6)

- **Protection Rooted in Pattern:** Daniel's deliverance was not a last-minute divine whim. It was the direct result of a lifelong pattern of faithful devotion. His open windows were a testament to a consistent character. His protection was earned in the daily discipline of prayer, long before the crisis arrived. This teaches that our response in a crisis is often determined by our daily habits.
- **The Nature of God's Intervention:** God did not prevent Daniel from being thrown into the den; He protected him *within* it. This is a crucial distinction. God's protection does not always mean the avoidance of trouble, but often His victorious presence *through* it. The angel's presence signifies that God's supernatural resources are deployed for those who are faithful.
- **The Public Vindication of Faith:** The outcome was a powerful evangelistic tool. King Darius, a pagan monarch, issued a decree praising the "living God" of Daniel. Daniel's

private faithfulness resulted in a public declaration of God's glory, demonstrating that our trials can become platforms for God's fame.

D. DIVINE PROVISION: Learning Dependence in the Wilderness

- **Provision as Pedagogy:** The manna was a daily lesson in dependence. It could not be hoarded, forcing Israel to trust God anew each morning. This directly informs Jesus' teaching on daily bread (Matthew 6:11). God's provision is often given in ways that cultivate trust and prevent self-sufficiency.
- **Provision Through Partnership:** The widow of Zarephath (1 Kings 17) had to actively participate in her miracle by giving her last meal to Elijah. This principle of "seed faith"—giving out of our lack in obedience to God's word—unlocks supernatural provision.
- **The Conditional Nature of Provision:** The cessation of manna in Canaan (Joshua 5:12) shows that God's methods change. He provides miraculously in the wilderness, but expects diligent labor in the land of promise. Furthermore, persistent disobedience can break the cycle of provision, as seen in the famines God used to call Israel to repentance.

EVALUATION & APPLICATION (Week 4)

1. **Personal Reflection:** Describe a "Red Sea moment" in your own life or that of someone you know. What would it have looked like to "stand firm" and then "move on" in that situation?
2. **Scenario Analysis:** A believer is offered a high-paying job in a company known for unethical practices. Walk through how they could use the five methods of God's guidance to make a decision.
3. **Comparative Theology:** Contrast God's *preventative* protection for Daniel with His *deliverance* through trial for the three Hebrews in the fiery furnace (Daniel 3). What does this teach about the different ways God manifests His care?

4. **Practical Faith:** If "obedience is the key to provision," what is one step of obedience God might be asking of you now in your finances, time, or talents?
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WEEK 6: THE COST OF NEGLECT - ELI AND THE FAILURE OF PRIORITIES

THEME: When Leadership Fails at Home

A. THE SINS OF HOPHNI AND PHINEHAS: A Case Study in Spiritual Decay

The sons of Eli did not simply make mistakes; they committed high-handed, presumptuous sins that revealed a profound contempt for God Himself.

- **Sacrilege in the Sanctuary:** By demanding raw meat, they violated the core of the sacrificial system, treating God's portion with greed. This was not just theft; it was a public declaration that their appetites were more important than God's holiness.
- **Immorality at the Doorway:** Their sexual sin with the women serving at the Tabernacle profaned the very place where God met with His people. It blurred the lines between the holy and the profane, creating a toxic environment.
- **The Diagnostic: "They had no regard for the Lord"** (1 Samuel 2:12). This is the root of all their sins. The problem was not a lack of ritual knowledge—they were priests—but a lack of relational reverence for God.

B. ELI'S PARENTAL FAILURE: The Sin of Omission

Eli's tragedy is that he was a judge in Israel but not in his own home. His failure provides a timeless warning about the perils of passive leadership.

- **The Feeble Rebuke:** His words, "**Why do you do such things?**" (1 Samuel 2:23), were an appeal to reason, not a pronouncement of judgment. He addressed the *consequences* (the bad report) rather than the *character* of the sin (rebellion against God).
- **God's Indictment:** The Lord's message through the prophet was devastating in its clarity: "**You honor your sons more than me**" (1 Samuel 2:29). By failing to remove them from office, Eli prioritized his sons' positions and his own comfort over God's honor. The

specific charge was that "**he failed to restrain them**" (1 Samuel 3:13). In God's eyes, knowing about sin and failing to act is complicity.

C. THE IRREVERSIBLE CONSEQUENCES: A House Demolished

The judgment on Eli's house was swift, severe, and symbolic.

5. **The Immediate Curse:** The death of Hophni and Phinehas on the same day was a direct, public execution of divine justice.
6. **The Generational Curse:** The loss of the priesthood was a permanent stripping of privilege and legacy. God would raise up a "faithful priest" (1 Samuel 2:35), later fulfilled in Zadok, showing that God's work will continue, but not through those who abuse their privilege.
7. **The Tragic Fulfillment:** The death of Eli—breaking his neck upon hearing the Ark was captured—symbolized the complete collapse of the spiritual structure he was meant to uphold. His physical death mirrored the spiritual death of his lineage.

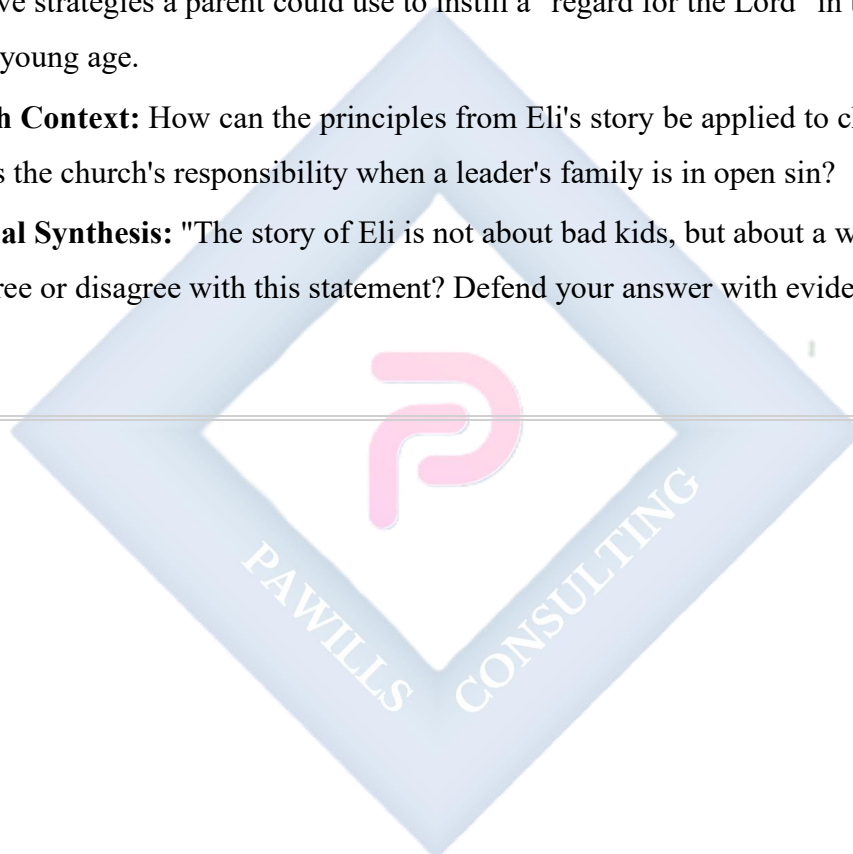
D. MODERN APPLICATIONS: Beyond Parenting to Discipleship

The story of Eli is a paradigm for all who hold spiritual influence.

8. **For Parents: The Ministry of Restraint:** Effective parenting involves more than teaching what is right; it involves creating boundaries and enforcing consequences that "restrain" a child from destructive paths. This is a proactive, often uncomfortable, work of love.
9. **For Leaders: The Primacy of Character:** Whether a pastor, teacher, or group leader, public ministry is invalidated by private compromise, especially within one's own household (1 Timothy 3:4-5).
10. **For All Believers: The Courage to Confront:** Eli's fear of his sons is a warning against the "fear of man" (Proverbs 29:25). We are called to lovingly confront sin in our spheres of influence, trusting God more than we fear the reaction of others.
11. **The Danger of Familiarity:** Growing up in a religious environment (like the Tabernacle) can lead to a casual, disrespectful attitude toward holy things. This story warns against treating God's grace and calling as a trivial matter.

EVALUATION & APPLICATION (Week 6)

12. **Heart Check:** In what area of your life (e.g., friendships, entertainment choices, use of time) might you be "honoring" someone or something more than God? What would it look like to repent of this?
13. **Practical Plan:** Create a "Parenting Plan" based on the failures of Eli. List three proactive strategies a parent could use to instill a "regard for the Lord" in their children from a young age.
14. **Church Context:** How can the principles from Eli's story be applied to church discipline? What is the church's responsibility when a leader's family is in open sin?
15. **Personal Synthesis:** "The story of Eli is not about bad kids, but about a weak father." Do you agree or disagree with this statement? Defend your answer with evidence from the text.



WEEK 8: CONSEQUENCES OF OBEDIENCE AND DISOBEDIENCE

1. Meaning of Obedience

Obedience is the act of willingly following instructions, commands, or laws given by a person in authority or a governing body. In a societal context, it means adhering to the rules and regulations that ensure peace, order, and smooth functioning. From a religious perspective, it is about aligning our actions with God's will and commandments.

Illustration: Think of a traffic light. Obeying the red light by stopping, even when no one is watching, is an act of obedience that ensures your safety and the safety of others. Disobeying it can lead to accidents, injury, or fines.

2. Biblical Examples of Obedience

A. David's Obedience to God's Law (1 Samuel 26:1-12)

- **The Situation:** King Saul, driven by jealousy, was hunting David to kill him. David and his men found Saul and his entire army asleep. David's companion, Abishai, saw a golden opportunity and urged David to let him kill Saul with his own spear.
- **The Act of Obedience:** Despite the personal risk and the clear chance to eliminate his enemy, David refused. He declared, *"Who can lay a hand on the Lord's anointed and be guiltless?"* (1 Samuel 26:9). He chose to obey God's command, *"You shall not murder"* (Exodus 20:13), over his human desire for self-preservation and revenge. He only took Saul's spear and water jug as proof that he had been there.
- **Consequences of David's Obedience:**
 - a. **Divine Protection:** God continued to protect and preserve David's life throughout his years of fleeing from Saul.
 - b. **Kingship Fulfilled:** Because he respected God's authority, God honored him. Saul later died in battle, and David became the next king of Israel, as God had promised.

B. Joseph's Obedience to God's Law (Genesis 39:7-12)

- **The Situation:** Joseph was a slave in the house of Potiphar in Egypt. Potiphar's wife repeatedly tried to seduce him.
- **The Act of Obedience:** Joseph refused her advances, stating, *"How then can I do this great wickedness and sin against God?"* (Genesis 39:9). He obeyed the command, *"You shall not commit adultery"* (Exodus 20:14). His obedience was so firm that he literally ran away from the temptation.
- **Consequences of Joseph's Obedience:**
 - c. **Temporary Suffering, Ultimate Promotion:** His obedience led to false accusations and imprisonment. However, because God was with him, he found favor even in prison and was put in charge of other prisoners.
 - d. **Prosperity and Fulfillment:** God ultimately delivered Joseph from prison and elevated him to the position of Prime Minister of Egypt, where he saved countless lives, including his own family.

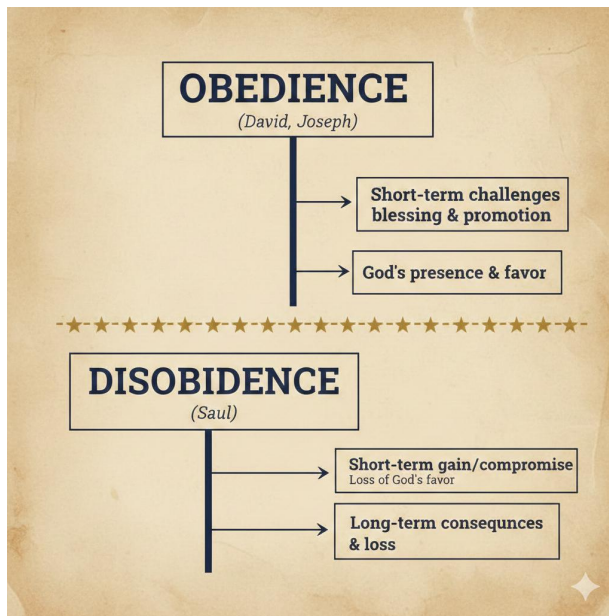
3. Biblical Example of Disobedience

A. Saul's Disobedience (1 Samuel 15:1-9, 20-26)

- **The Command:** God gave King Saul a clear and direct command through the prophet Samuel: to completely destroy the Amalekites and all their possessions as an act of divine judgment.
- **The Act of Disobedience:** Saul defeated the Amalekites but spared the best of the sheep, cattle, and their king, Agag. He directly disobeyed God's specific instructions.
- **The Excuse:** When confronted by Samuel, Saul blamed the people and claimed the spared animals were for sacrifice. He showed no genuine repentance.
- **Consequences of Saul's Disobedience:**

- e. **Rejection as King:** God rejected Saul as king. Samuel declared, “*Because you have rejected the word of the Lord, he has rejected you as king*” (1 Samuel 15:23).
- f. **Spiritual Torment:** The Spirit of the Lord departed from Saul, and he was tormented by an evil spirit (1 Samuel 16:14).
- g. **Tragic Death:** Saul and his sons died a tragic death in battle against the Philistines, and his kingdom was given to another (David).

Summary Illustration: The Ladder of Consequences



4. Evaluation Questions

16. Compare and contrast the obedience of David and Joseph. What similar character traits did they display?
17. Why was Saul's disobedience considered so severe by God?
18. Describe a modern-day situation where obeying a rule (at school, home, or society) might be difficult but is the right thing to do. What could be the consequences of obedience vs. disobedience in that case?

WEEK 9: FRIENDSHIP

1. Concept of Friendship

Friendship is a warm, close, and trusting relationship between two or more people who care for, support, and are emotionally attached to one another. It is built on mutual affection, trust, and shared experiences. Jesus himself modeled deep friendships with his disciples and others.

2. Biblical Examples of Friendship

A. Jesus, Martha, and Mary (Luke 10:38-42)

- **The Story:** Jesus was a close friend of the siblings Martha, Mary, and Lazarus. During one visit, Martha was busy with the tasks of hospitality (“much serving”), while Mary sat at Jesus’ feet, listening to his teaching.
- **The Conflict:** Martha complained to Jesus, asking Him to tell Mary to help her.
- **The Lesson:** Jesus gently corrected Martha, saying, *“You are worried and upset about many things, but few things are needed—or indeed only one. Mary has chosen what is better, and it will not be taken away from her.”* This story highlights that true friendship with Jesus involves prioritizing spiritual connection over mere busyness.
- **Characteristics Demonstrated:** Hospitality, intimacy, honest communication, and the value of spiritual companionship.

B. Jesus and Lazarus (John 11:1-44)

- **The Story:** When their brother Lazarus was sick, Mary and Martha immediately sent for their friend, Jesus, saying, *“Lord, the one you love is sick.”* Jesus delayed, and Lazarus died. Upon arriving, Jesus was deeply moved by their grief and wept with them—a powerful display of empathetic friendship.

- **The Act of Power and Love:** Jesus then raised Lazarus from the dead, demonstrating that His friendship involves transformative power and the ultimate victory over sorrow and death.
- **Characteristics Demonstrated:** Deep love, shared grief, empathy, reliability in crisis, and powerful support.

3. Types of Friendship

Type of Friend	Description	Biblical Example
The Confidant (True Friend)	A close, loyal friend who knows you deeply, keeps your secrets, and sticks with you through good and bad times.	Jonathan to David (1 Samuel 18:1-4). He protected David from his own father, Saul.
The Acquaintance	Someone you know and are friendly with, but the relationship is casual and not deeply personal.	The crowds that followed Jesus; they were friendly but not committed disciples.
The Fair-Weather Friend	A friend who is only around when things are going well but disappears during trouble or hardship.	The disciples who left Jesus when his teachings became hard (John 6:66).
The Betrayer (Bad Friend)	Someone who pretends to be a friend but ultimately acts out of self-interest and betrays your trust.	Judas Iscariot , who was one of the Twelve but betrayed Jesus for money (Matthew 26:14-16).

4. Characteristics of Good and Bad Friends

Good Friends (The "Green Flags")	Bad Friends (The "Red Flags")
✓ Trustworthy & Loyal (They keep your secrets)	✗ Gossipy & Betraying (They share your private information)
✓ Supportive & Encouraging (They cheer for your success)	✗ Jealous & Competitive (They put you down to feel better)

Good Friends (The "Green Flags")	Bad Friends (The "Red Flags")
✓ Honest & Forgiving (They tell you the truth in love)	✗ Dishonest & Manipulative (They lie and pressure you into wrong things)
✓ Reliable (They show up when they say they will)	✗ Unreliable (They constantly cancel plans or let you down)
✓ Respectful (They respect your boundaries, faith, and values)	✗ Disrespectful (They mock your beliefs or ignore your feelings)

5. Evaluation Questions

19. Using the table above, categorize the different types of friends Jesus had during his ministry and give examples.
20. What lessons about friendship can we learn from the relationship between Jesus and Lazarus?
21. If a friend started pressuring you to cheat on a test, what characteristics of a "bad friend" would they be displaying? What would a "good friend" do instead?

WEEK 10: TRUST IN GOD (SUBMISSION TO THE WILL OF GOD)

1. David's Trust in God's Timing

A. Saul Seeks to Kill David (1 Samuel 18-24) King Saul became intensely jealous of David after David's military successes. This jealousy turned into a murderous obsession. Saul made multiple attempts on David's life:

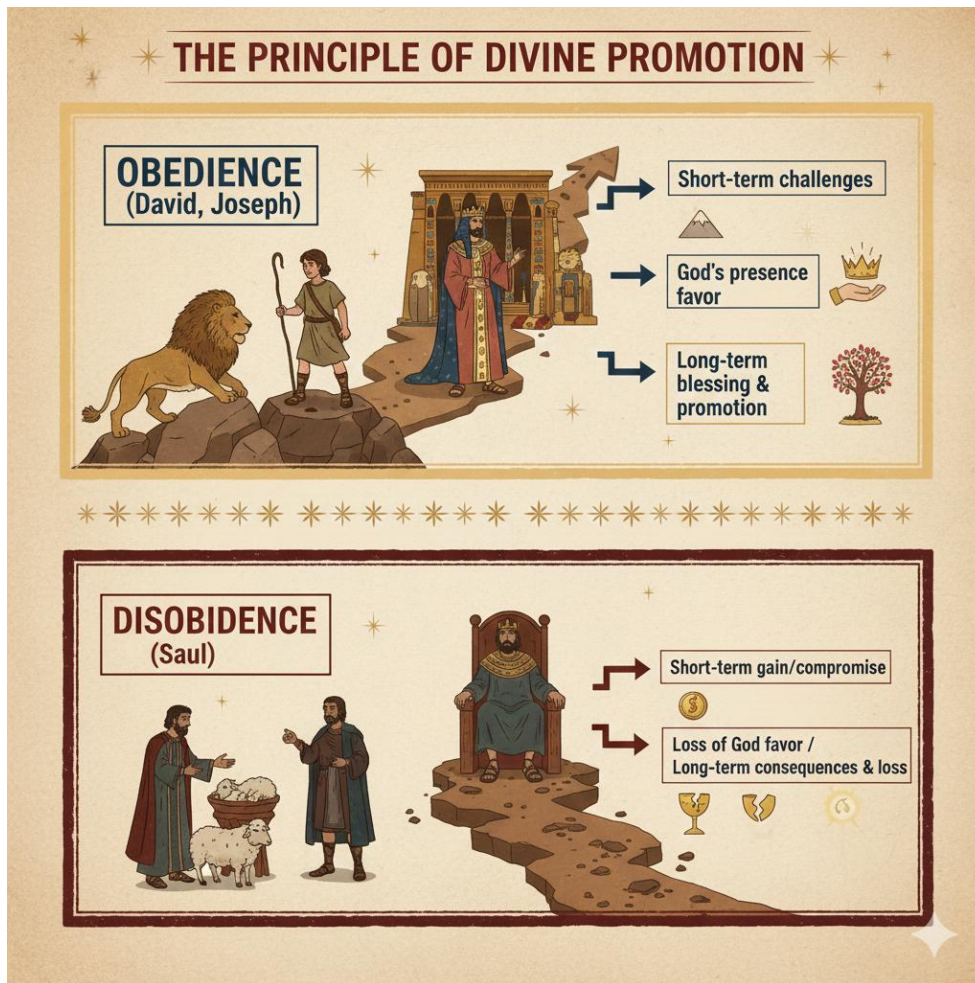
- **With a Spear:** He tried to pin David to the wall while David was playing the harp for him.
- **Through Deception:** He demanded 100 Philistine foreskins as a dowry for his daughter Michal, hoping David would be killed trying to get them. David trusted God and returned with 200.
- **Through Pursuit:** David was forced to become a fugitive, constantly hiding from Saul's armies.

B. David Spares Saul's Life – Twice! (1 Samuel 24 & 26) David had two clear opportunities to kill Saul and end his suffering.

- **First Opportunity (Cave of En Gedi - 1 Samuel 24):** Saul entered a cave where David and his men were hiding. David's men saw it as divine delivery. Instead of killing Saul, David crept forward and cut off a corner of Saul's robe, later showing it as proof that he meant no harm.
- **Second Opportunity (Wilderness of Ziph - 1 Samuel 26):** David and Abishai found Saul's entire camp asleep. Abishai begged for permission to strike. David responded, *"Don't destroy him! Who can lay a hand on the Lord's anointed and be guiltless?"* Instead, he took Saul's spear and water jug.
- **Why David Didn't Kill Saul: David's Trust in Action**
 - a. **Respect for God's Authority:** David believed Saul was anointed by God, and only God had the right to remove him.
 - b. **Trust in God's Timing:** He refused to take matters into his own hands, trusting that God would make him king in His own time and way.

- c. **Refusal to Commit Sin:** He knew that murdering God's anointed king was a sin, and his trust in God was greater than his desire for the throne.

Illustration: The Principle of Divine Promotion



2. Jonah's Struggle with Submission

A. Running from God's Will (Jonah 1)

- **The Command:** God told Jonah to go to Nineveh (a hostile, enemy city) and preach a message of repentance.
- **The Disobedience:** Instead of trusting God's plan, Jonah ran in the opposite direction, boarding a ship to Tarshish. He disobeyed out of fear, prejudice, and a lack of trust in God's mercy for Israel's enemies.

- **The Consequence:** God sent a violent storm. Jonah was thrown overboard and swallowed by a great fish.

B. Submitting in Hardship (Jonah 2)

- **The Turning Point:** In the belly of the fish, Jonah prayed a prayer of desperation and repentance. He acknowledged God's sovereignty.
- **The Result:** After three days and nights, the fish vomited Jonah onto dry land, giving him a second chance.

Contrasting David and Jonah:

	David	Jonah
Situation	Unjustly persecuted	Given a difficult mission
Initial Response	Trust & Wait on God	Distrust & Run from God
Action	Spared his enemy	Fled from his mission
Heart Posture	Submission to God's will	Resistance to God's will
Outcome	Ultimately blessed and established	Corrected and recommissioned

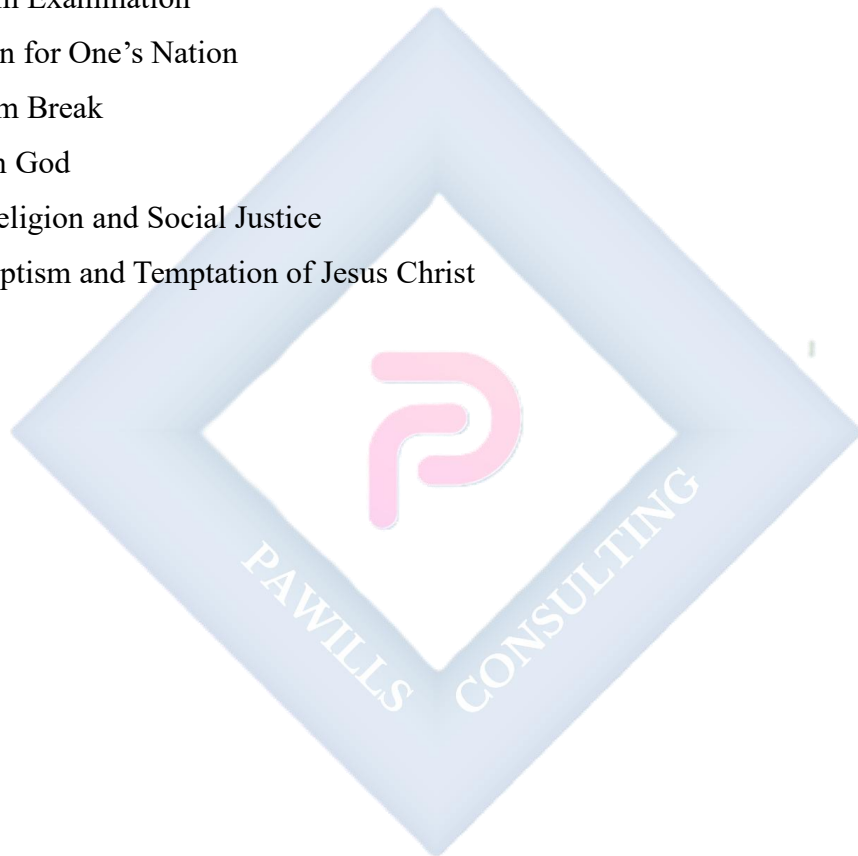
3. Evaluation Questions

1. David had every human reason to kill Saul. List two reasons *for* killing him and two reasons *against* it, based on his trust in God.
2. Why is it sometimes difficult to submit to God's will, as seen in the story of Jonah? Can you think of a modern example?
3. What does the phrase "Trust in God's Timing" mean in practical terms for a student facing a difficult situation like exam failure or a family problem?

SS2 CHRISTIAN RELIGIOUS STUDIES LESSON NOTES

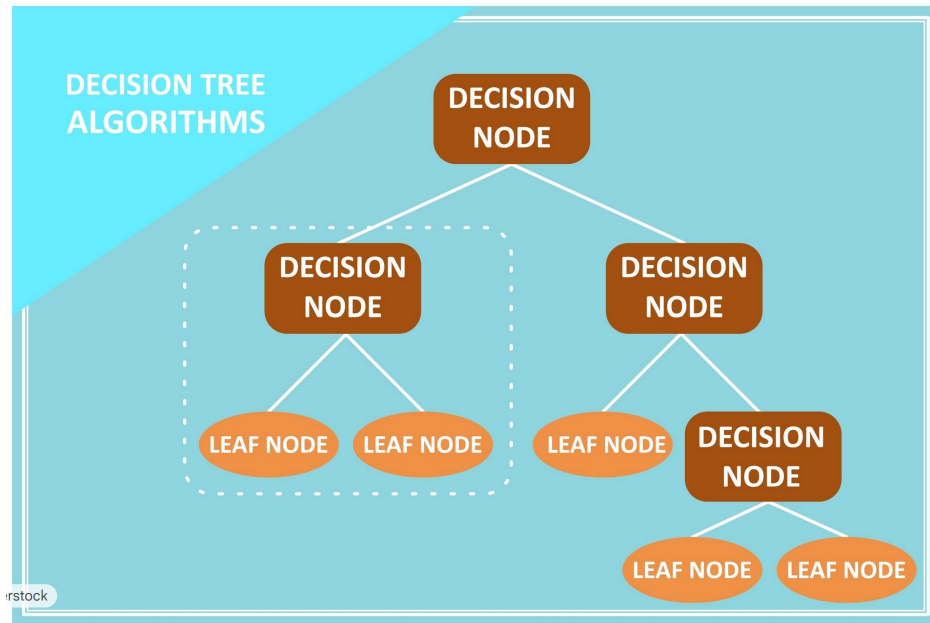
SECOND TERM

- 1 Making Decisions As A Christian
- 2 Greed and its Effect
- 3 The Supremacy of God
- 4 Religious Reforms
- 5 Midterm Examination
- 6 Concern for One's Nation
- 7 Midterm Break
- 8 Faith In God
- 9 True Religion and Social Justice
- 10 The Baptism and Temptation of Jesus Christ



WEEK 1: MAKING DECISIONS AS A CHRISTIAN

1. The Foundation of Good Decisions: Wisdom

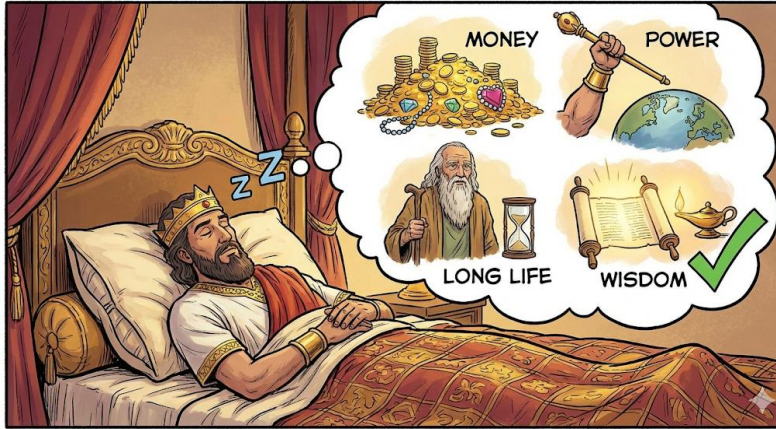


Visual Suggestion: A simple diagram showing how one decision branches into different outcomes.

Example: Imagine you have to choose between studying for an exam or going to a party. The wise decision considers the long-term consequence (good grades) over the short-term pleasure (a few hours of fun). Wisdom is the ability to make that choice correctly.

2. Solomon: The Paradigm of Wise Decision-Making

A. The Request for Wisdom (1 Kings 3:3-14)



- **The Divine Offer:** God appeared to Solomon in a dream and made an extraordinary offer: "Ask for whatever you want me to give you."
- **Solomon's Humble Request:** Instead of asking for wealth or power, Solomon asked for "a discerning heart to govern your people and to distinguish between right and wrong."
- **God's Response:** God was so pleased with this request that He granted Solomon unprecedented wisdom, plus the riches and honor he didn't ask for.

B. The Demonstration of Wisdom (1 Kings 3:16-28)



- **The Case:** Two prostitutes came to Solomon, both claiming to be the mother of the same baby.

- **The Test:** Solomon called for a sword and declared, "Cut the living child in two and give half to one and half to the other."
- **The Verdict:** The real mother, filled with compassion, immediately offered to give up the baby to save its life. The impostor agreed with the gruesome solution. Solomon thus identified the true mother and gave her the child.
- **Consequences of His Wisdom:**
 - National awe and respect for his leadership.
 - Peace and prosperity throughout his kingdom (1 Kings 4:20-25).
 - International fame, with leaders like the Queen of Sheba coming to test his wisdom (1 Kings 10:1-7).

3. The Downfall: Solomon's Unwise Decisions



- **Forced Labor & Heavy Taxes (1 Kings 9:15-23; 12:4):** To fund his massive building projects, Solomon imposed forced labor and heavy taxes, oppressing the very people he was called to lead wisely.

- **Disobedience in Marriage (1 Kings 11:1-8):** Despite God's clear warning, Solomon married hundreds of foreign women. To please them, he built pagan altars and participated in idol worship, directly disobeying God's command.
- **The Result:** God pronounced judgment: the kingdom would be torn away from Solomon's son, leading to a civil war.

Illustrative Chart: Solomon's Decision Contrast

Wise Decisions (Early Reign)	Unwise Decisions (Late Reign)
Asked God for wisdom	Relied on his own understanding
Served the people	Used the people for his projects
Obedied God's commands	Compromised with idolatry
Result: United, Prosperous Kingdom	Result: Divided, Weakened Kingdom

4. Rehoboam's Foolish Decision (1 Kings 12:1-20)

Visual Suggestion: A split image. On one side, Rehoboam listening to the wise old advisors. On the other, him with the young, arrogant friends.

- **The People's Request:** After Solomon's death, the people asked his son, Rehoboam, to lighten the heavy burdens his father had placed on them.
- **The Two Counsels:**
 - **The Elders:** Advised kindness and service to gain the people's loyalty.
 - **The Young Peers:** Advised harsher rule and increased burdens to show strength.
- **The Catastrophic Choice:** Rehoboam rejected the wise counsel and followed the foolish advice, threatening the people with even greater oppression.
- **The Consequence:** The ten northern tribes rebelled and formed their own kingdom (Israel), leaving Rehoboam with only two tribes (Judah). The united kingdom of Israel was permanently shattered.

5. Lessons for Christian Decision-Making Today

1. **Seek Godly Wisdom First:** Before making major decisions, pray for discernment, as Solomon did initially (James 1:5).
 2. **Beware of Compromise:** Small compromises in your values (like who you associate with or what you tolerate) can lead to major spiritual downfall.
 3. **Listen to Wise Counsel:** Surround yourself with mature, godly advisors, not just people who tell you what you want to hear.
 4. **Your Decisions Affect Others:** Leadership decisions, and even personal ones, have a ripple effect on your family, friends, and community.
-

6. Evaluation & Discussion

1. If God appeared to you today with the same offer He gave Solomon, what would you ask for and why?
 2. Create a modern-day scenario similar to Rehoboam's dilemma (e.g., a class president deciding between popular but wrong advice and right but unpopular advice). How should a Christian leader respond?
 3. Identify three practical ways a student can seek God's wisdom when facing a difficult choice.
-

WEEK 2: GREED AND ITS EFFECTS

1. Understanding Greed

Greed is the intense and selfish desire for something, especially wealth, power, or food, beyond what one needs. It is a "heart condition" that says, "I must have that, and I'll do anything to get it."



A picture of a person with a small, empty cup trying to fill it from a giant, overflowing bucket. The cup can never be filled, illustrating the insatiable nature of greed.

Example: A student who already has a good grade but cheats on an exam to get a perfect score, potentially getting others in trouble.

2. Case Study 1: Ahab & Jezebel - Greed for Property (1 Kings 21:1-29)



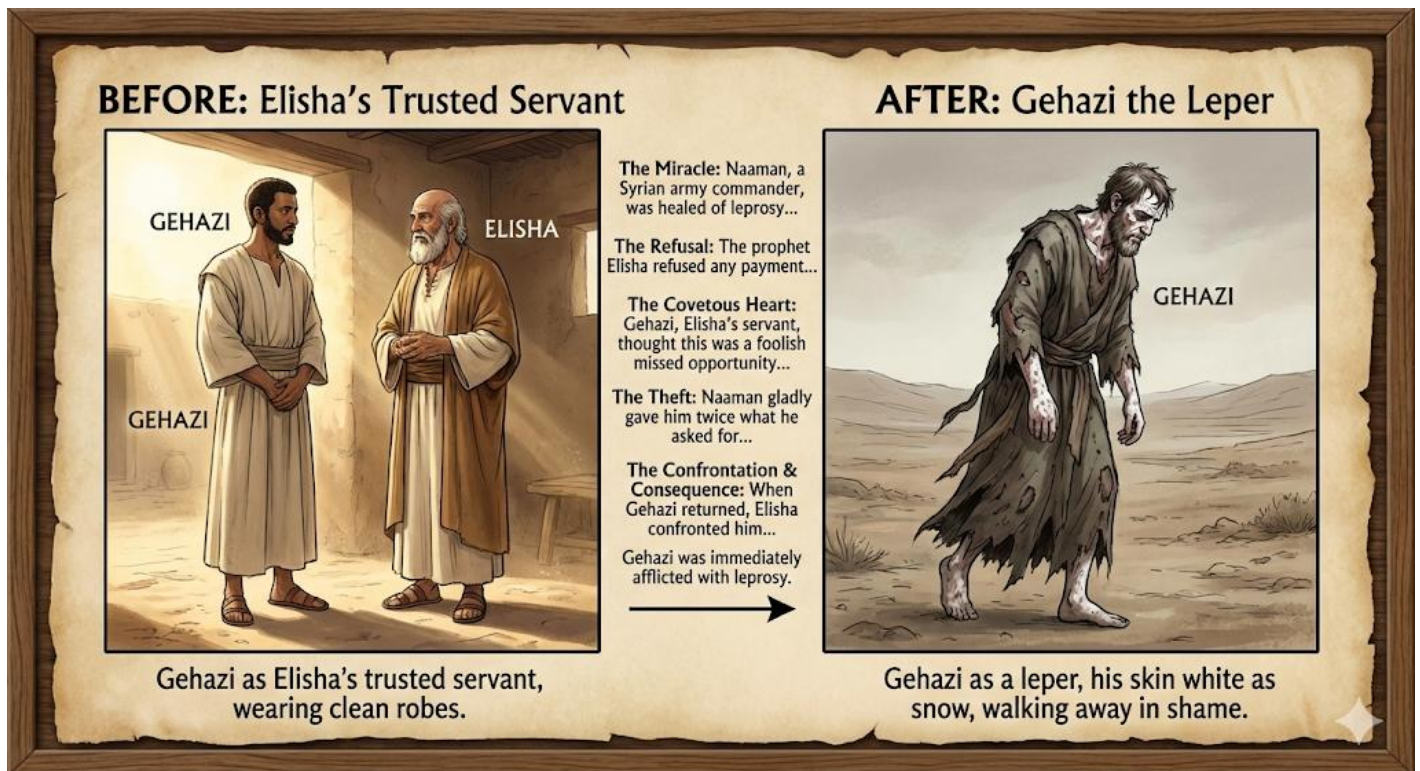
- **The Desire:** King Ahab coveted his neighbor Naboth's vineyard because it was close to his palace and would make a nice vegetable garden.
- **The Obstacle:** Naboth refused to sell, citing God's law that the land was his family's inheritance.
- **The Sinful Plot:** Queen Jezebel, seeing Ahab's despair, orchestrated a scheme. She had two false witnesses accuse Naboth of cursing God and the king, leading to Naboth's execution by stoning.
- **The "Success":** With Naboth dead, Ahab took possession of the vineyard.

Consequences of Their Greed:

- **Divine Judgment:** God sent the prophet Elijah to pronounce a terrifying curse: Ahab's dynasty would be wiped out, and Jezebel would be eaten by dogs.
- **A Legacy of Bloodshed:** Their greed set in motion a chain of violence that ended in the brutal deaths of Ahab, Jezebel, and all their sons, just as Elijah prophesied.

Lesson: Greed can lead you to justify horrible actions, but the consequences are inescapable and often affect more than just you.

3. Case Study 2: Gehazi - Greed for Possessions (2 Kings 5:1-27)



Lesson: Greed makes you dishonest and blinds you to the value of integrity. It can cost you your reputation, your health, and your future in a single moment.

4. The Antidote: Lessons from Naaman's Healing

While the main story is about greed, Naaman's healing provides a positive contrast:

- **Humility Precedes Blessing:** Naaman had to swallow his pride and obey a simple, seemingly foolish command to be healed.
- **God's Gifts are Free:** Elisha's refusal of payment highlights that God's salvation and blessings are gifts of grace, not for sale. This is the very principle Gehazi violated.

5. Modern-Day Applications



Discussion: How can greed manifest in a school environment? (e.g., cheating to be top of the class, bullying to take someone's lunch money, spreading rumors to win a student government election).

6. Evaluation & Discussion

1. Compare and contrast the greed of Ahab and Gehazi. How were their desires similar, and how were their methods different?
2. Why is Elisha's refusal of Naaman's gifts such a powerful part of the story? What does it teach us about God's character?
3. **Scenario Analysis:** Your friend buys a new, expensive video game. They leave it at your house by mistake. You've always wanted this game. What does the greedy choice look like? What does the righteous choice look like, based on the lessons from this week?

WEEK 3: THE SUPREMACY OF GOD

1. Meaning of Supremacy

Supremacy is the state of having the highest authority, ultimate power, and supreme status. To say God is **supreme** means He is the ultimate ruler over all creation. He is the Creator, and everything else is the creation. He has absolute and unlimited power over the entire universe.

Illustration: Think of a master potter and a lump of clay. The potter has complete control to shape, mold, and design the clay as he wishes. The clay cannot tell the potter what to do. In the same way, God is the Potter, and we are the clay (Isaiah 64:8).

2. Biblical Demonstrations of God's Supremacy

The Bible is filled with stories that show God's supreme power over nature, life, and death.

- **Over Nature:** In **Joshua 10:12-13**, Joshua prayed, and the sun and moon stood still until Israel won a battle. This shows God's command over the cosmos.
 - **Over Rebellion:** In **Numbers 16:30-33**, the earth opened its mouth and swallowed Korah and his rebels who challenged God's authority, showing His supreme judgment.
 - **Over Impossibility:** In **1 Kings 17**, during a severe drought, God commanded ravens to bring food to Elijah and ensured a widow's jar of flour and jug of oil never ran out, showing His supreme provision.
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3. The Great Challenge: Baalism in Israel (1 Kings 16:29-34)

King Ahab and his wife, Queen Jezebel, officially introduced the worship of **Baal** in Israel. Baal was a Canaanite god believed to control rain and fertility. Ahab built a temple for Baal, set up an altar, and promoted this false worship, leading the nation away from the one true God.

The Resulting Religious Tension (1 Kings 18:3-6):

- **Persecution:** Jezebel began killing the prophets of the Lord. A faithful man named Obadiah risked his life to hide 100 prophets in caves to save them.
 - **Fear and Secrecy:** Worshiping God became dangerous. Many Israelites abandoned their faith out of fear or were deceived into worshiping Baal.
 - **Divine Judgment:** To prove He, not Baal, controlled the weather, God sent a severe drought for three years through the prophet Elijah. This drought caused widespread famine and suffering.
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4. The Showdown on Mount Carmel (1 Kings 18:17-46)

This is the dramatic story of how God demonstrated His supremacy publicly.

A. The Set-Up: Elijah challenged the 450 prophets of Baal to a contest on Mount Carmel. The rules were simple: each side would prepare a bull sacrifice on an altar but not light the fire. The true god would be the one who answered by sending fire from heaven to consume the offering.

B. The Failure of Baal:

- The prophets of Baal prayed, danced, and shouted from morning until noon. "No one answered."
- Elijah mocked them, suggesting maybe Baal was busy, traveling, or sleeping.
- They even cut themselves with swords and spears, a desperate and bloody display. Still, "there was no voice, no one answered, no one paid attention."

C. The Triumph of God:

- Elijah rebuilt the Lord's altar with 12 stones, representing the 12 tribes of Israel.
- To remove all doubt, he drenched the sacrifice and the altar with **four large jars of water, three times** (12 jars total), until the trench around the altar was filled.
- Elijah prayed a simple, powerful prayer: "Let it be known today that you are God in Israel... Answer me, so these people will know that you, Lord, are God."
- **Immediately, the fire of the Lord fell.** It consumed the burnt offering, the wood, the stones, the soil, and even licked up all the water in the trench!

The People's Response: They fell on their faces and cried out, "**The Lord, He is God! The Lord, He is God!**"

The Outcome: Elijah executed the false prophets, and God ended the three-year drought with a heavy rain, proving His control over both fire and water.

5. Moral Lessons

1. **God's supremacy is undeniable.** No false god, ideology, or human power can successfully challenge His ultimate authority.
 2. **Standing for God requires courage.** Like Elijah, we should be brave in defending our faith, even when we feel outnumbered.
 3. **God uses circumstances to redirect us.** The drought was a severe hardship, but it was used to bring the people of Israel back to their senses and back to God.
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6. Evaluation & Discussion

1. In your own words, what does "the supremacy of God" mean?
 2. Create a modern-day skit script outlining the key scenes from the Mount Carmel contest.
 3. What are some "modern Baals" that people today might be tempted to trust instead of God (e.g., money, science, fame, self)? How does this story challenge us to put God first?
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WEEK 4: RELIGIOUS REFORMS UNDER KING JOSIAH

1. What is Religious Reform?

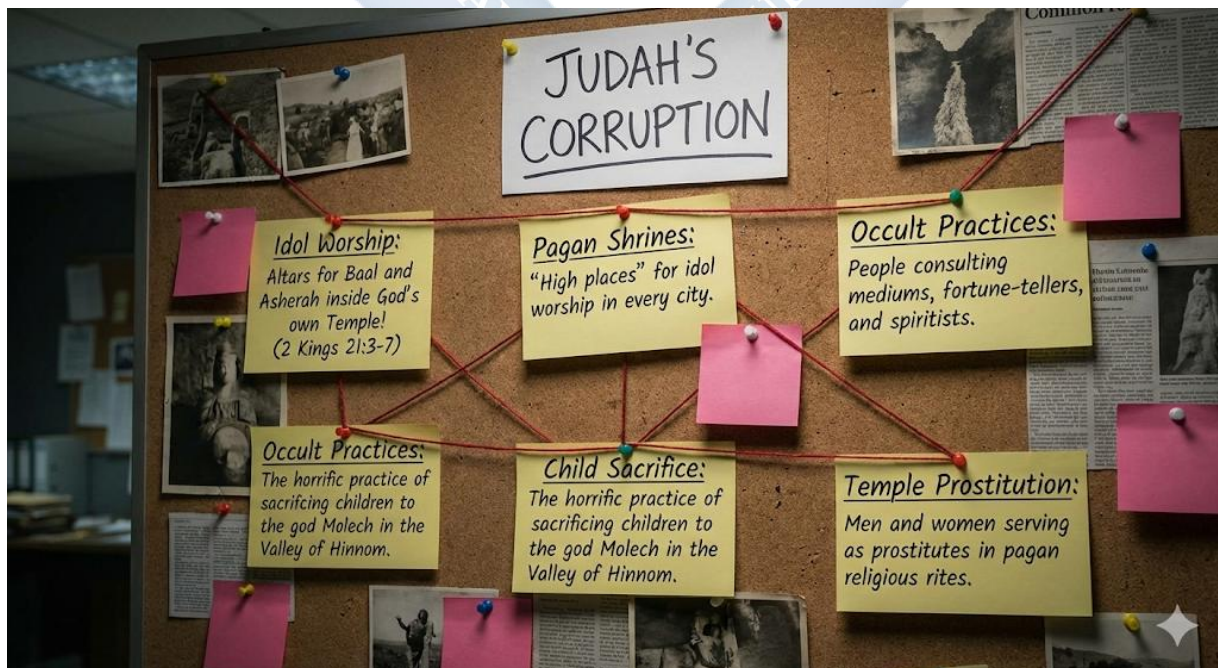
Reform means to make changes in something in order to improve it and correct what is wrong, corrupt, or unsatisfactory.

Religious reform, therefore, is the process of bringing a community's religious practices and beliefs back in line with the true and pure worship of God after a period of corruption and disobedience.

Illustration: Imagine a school where the rules have been forgotten. Students are running in the halls, cheating on tests, and being disrespectful. A new principal arrives, finds the original rulebook, and reinstates the rules to restore order and purpose. Josiah was like that principal for Judah.

2. The Need for Reform: A Nation Gone Astray

When Josiah became king at age 8, the nation of Judah was spiritually sick. His grandfather,



King Manasseh, had filled the land with evil practices.

Idol Worship: Altars for Baal and Asherah inside God's own Temple! (2 Kings 21:3-7)

- **Pagan Shrines:** "High places" for idol worship in every city.
- **Occult Practices:** People consulting mediums, fortune-tellers, and spiritists.
- **Child Sacrifice:** The horrific practice of sacrificing children to the god Molech in the Valley of Hinnom.
- **Temple Prostitution:** Men and women serving as prostitutes in pagan religious rites.

The people had completely forgotten God's laws, and the official copy of the Law (likely the Book of Deuteronomy) had been lost for years.

3. The Spark: Discovering the Lost Law Book (2 Kings 22:8-20)

When Josiah was 26, he ordered repairs to the Temple. During the renovations, the high priest, Hilkiah, found "the Book of the Law." When it was read to Josiah, he was horrified. He realized how far the nation had strayed from God's commands and that God's fierce anger was directed against them for their disobedience. He tore his robes as a sign of deep grief and repentance.

4. The Confirmation: The Prophetess Huldah (2 Kings 22:14-20)

Josiah sent messengers to the prophetess Huldah to inquire of the Lord. Her message was twofold:

1. **Judgment:** Because of Judah's great sin, God's judgment was certain and would not be revoked.
2. **Mercy for Josiah:** Because Josiah had a humble and repentant heart, this disaster would not happen in his lifetime. "Your eyes will not see all the disaster I am going to bring on this place."

This prophecy motivated Josiah to act immediately.

5. Josiah's Reforms in Action (2 Kings 23:1-25)

Visual Suggestion: A flowchart titled "Josiah's Clean-Up Plan," with boxes connected by arrows showing the sequence of his reforms.

A. Public Renewal of the Covenant (v. 1-3): Josiah gathered all the people—leaders, priests, prophets, and ordinary citizens—and read the entire Book of the Law to them. He then publicly renewed the covenant, promising to follow God and keep His commands, and all the people pledged themselves to the covenant.

B. Cleaning House in Judah and Jerusalem (v. 4-14): Josiah became a spiritual cleanup commander:

- **Purged the Temple:** He removed all the idols and articles for Baal and Asherah from the Temple and burned them outside the city.
- **Fired Idolatrous Priests:** He deposed the pagan priests who led the people astray.
- **Tore Down Pagan Altars:** He destroyed the "high places" and altars all around Jerusalem and Judah, including those where child sacrifice occurred.
- **Defiled Pagan Sites:** He desecrated the Topheth in the Valley of Hinnom (where children were sacrificed) to make it ritually unclean and unusable.

C. Reforming the Northern Kingdom (v. 15-20): Josiah's zeal was so great that he even went into the former northern kingdom of Israel (which had already been conquered by Assyria) and destroyed the pagan altar at Bethel, fulfilling a prophecy made centuries before.

D. Restoring True Worship (v. 21-23): Finally, after all the false worship was removed, Josiah commanded the people to celebrate the **Passover**. This festival had not been observed properly for hundreds of years. This act restored the central celebration of God's salvation and faithfulness.

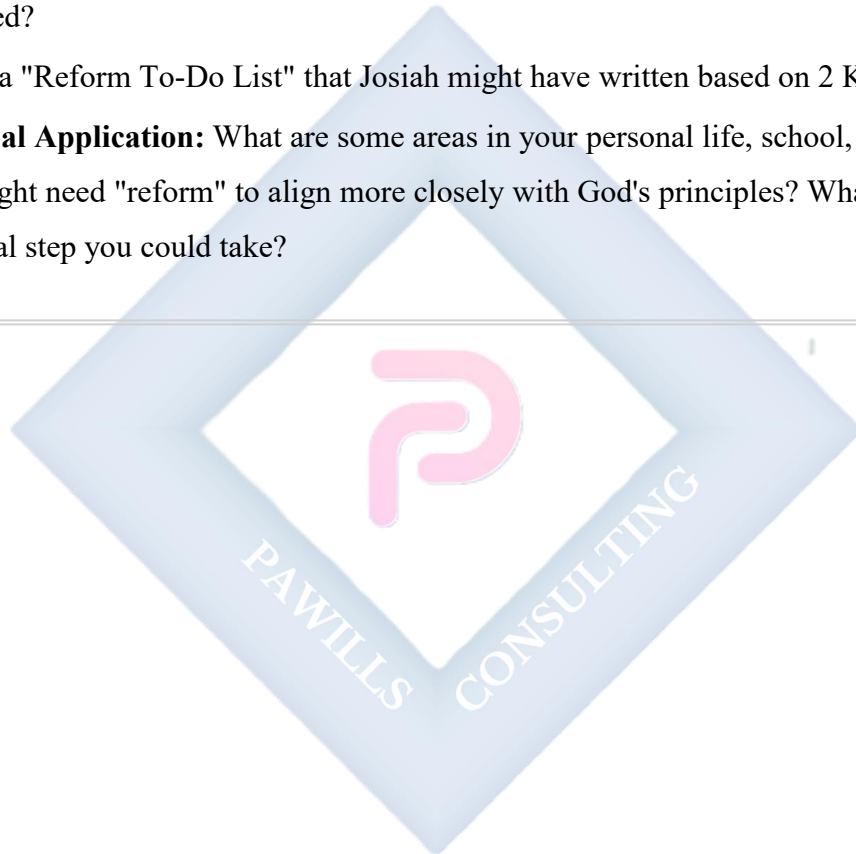
6. Lessons from Josiah's Reforms

1. **Ignorance of God's Word is dangerous.** Not knowing what God requires leads to sin and judgment.
2. **Repentance requires action.** True sorrow for sin leads to a decisive turn away from it.

3. **Reform starts with leadership.** One person's passion for God can inspire and lead an entire nation back to righteousness.
 4. **God honors a humble heart.** Josiah's humility and responsiveness to God's Word spared him from seeing the coming disaster.
-

7. Evaluation & Discussion

1. What is the connection between finding the Book of the Law and the reforms that followed?
 2. Create a "Reform To-Do List" that Josiah might have written based on 2 Kings 23.
 3. **Personal Application:** What are some areas in your personal life, school, or community that might need "reform" to align more closely with God's principles? What is one practical step you could take?
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WEEK 6: CONCERN FOR ONE'S NATION

Lesson Objectives:

By the end of this lesson, students should be able to:

1. Explain the political turmoil that led to the fall of Judah.
 2. Describe the response of key Jewish figures to the state of their nation.
 3. Identify reasons for the Jews' positive response to returning home.
 4. Relate the lessons from Nehemiah's actions to modern-day patriotism.
-

PART 1: THE DESTRUCTION OF A NATION (2 KINGS 24-25)

Introduction: A nation is a corporate entity that can face turbulent times—political, economic, or social. Showing concern for one's nation means identifying with these problems and working towards solutions. The nation of Israel provides a powerful example of this.

A Timeline of Turmoil:

- **Egypt's Interference:** Pharaoh Neco of Egypt invaded Judah, removed King Jehoahaz, and installed his brother Eliakim as a puppet king, renaming him Jehoiakim.
- **Babylon Takes Over:** Babylon, under King Nebuchadnezzar, defeated Egypt. Jehoiakim switched his allegiance to Babylon but later rebelled.
- **The First Siege:** Nebuchadnezzar sent armies to crush the rebellion. Jehoiakim died, and his young son, Jehoiachin, became king. Nebuchadnezzar besieged Jerusalem, captured Jehoiachin, and looted the temple treasures, taking the best and brightest citizens into exile (2 Kings 24:10-16).
- **The Final Destruction:** Nebuchadnezzar installed Zedekiah as king. When Zedekiah also rebelled, Babylon returned, laid a brutal siege, and captured the king. **Visual Suggestion:** A map showing the movements of the Egyptian and Babylonian armies towards Judah.

- **Tragic End:** Zedekiah was forced to watch his sons be executed, then was blinded and taken to Babylon. The city and Solomon's Temple were completely burned and destroyed (2 Kings 25:1-10).

Key Point: The biblical writers saw this destruction not just as a military defeat, but as a consequence of Judah's unfaithfulness to God (2 Kings 24:20).

PART 2: RESPONSE TO THE STATE OF THE NATION (EZRA & NEHEMIAH)

After the conquest, many Jews lived in exile in Babylon. When Persia defeated Babylon, King Cyrus issued a decree allowing the Jews to return home and rebuild.



Key Figures and Their Roles:

1. Zerubbabel: The Temple Builder (Ezra 1-6)

- Led the first group of about 50,000 exiles back to Jerusalem.
- His primary mission: Rebuild the Temple.

- Faced opposition from local enemies (e.g., Bishlam, Mithredath) but succeeded because "God was with them." The temple was completed 20 years after their return.

2. **Ezra: The Spiritual Reformer (Ezra 7, 10)**

- A scribe and expert in the Law of Moses.
- Led a second group of exiles back with the aim of teaching God's laws and carrying out religious reforms to purify the people.

3. **Nehemiah: The Wall Rebuilder (Nehemiah 1-6)**

- Held a trusted position as the cupbearer to the Persian King Artaxerxes.
- **His Concern:** When his brother Hanani reported that Jerusalem's walls were broken down and the people were in disgrace, Nehemiah was heartbroken (Nehemiah 1:4).
- **His Actions:**
 - **Prayed and Fasted:** He first turned to God in prayer (Nehemiah 1:5-11).
 - **Planned and Requested:** He asked the king for permission and resources to go and rebuild the walls.
 - **Executed and Persevered:** He inspected the walls secretly, mobilized the people, and faced down fierce opposition from Sanballat and Tobiah. The work was completed in just 52 days.

PART 3: REASONS FOR THE POSITIVE RESPONSE TO RETURN HOME

1. **National Pride and Identity:** The feeling that "home is home" and a deep-seated love for their homeland.
2. **Religious Freedom:** In a foreign land, they could not freely worship Yahweh or practice their customs centered on the Temple in Jerusalem.
3. **The Desire for Self-Determination:** To be free from the shadow of foreign domination and re-establish themselves as a people under God.

4. **Divine Promise:** They believed it was God's will and the fulfillment of His promise to restore them.
-

LESSONS TO LEARN

- **True Patriotism:** Like Nehemiah and others, we should use our skills, resources, and positions to serve and develop our nation, no matter where we are.
 - **Prayer and Action:** Concern must lead to prayer, and prayer must lead to action.
 - **Resilience:** Progress often faces opposition. Commitment and reliance on God lead to success.
-

EVALUATION

1. Trace the events that led Nehemiah to embark on rebuilding the walls of Jerusalem. What two qualities did he demonstrate that are essential for good leadership today?
 2. Describe the return of the exiles from Babylon. Give two reasons why many Jews chose to make the difficult journey back to Jerusalem.
 3. Identify four causes of social unrest in many African nations today and suggest one biblical solution for each.
 4. Relate Nehemiah's prayer when he received the news about Jerusalem's state. What does this teach us about the right response to bad news about our country?
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WEEK 8: FAITH IN GOD

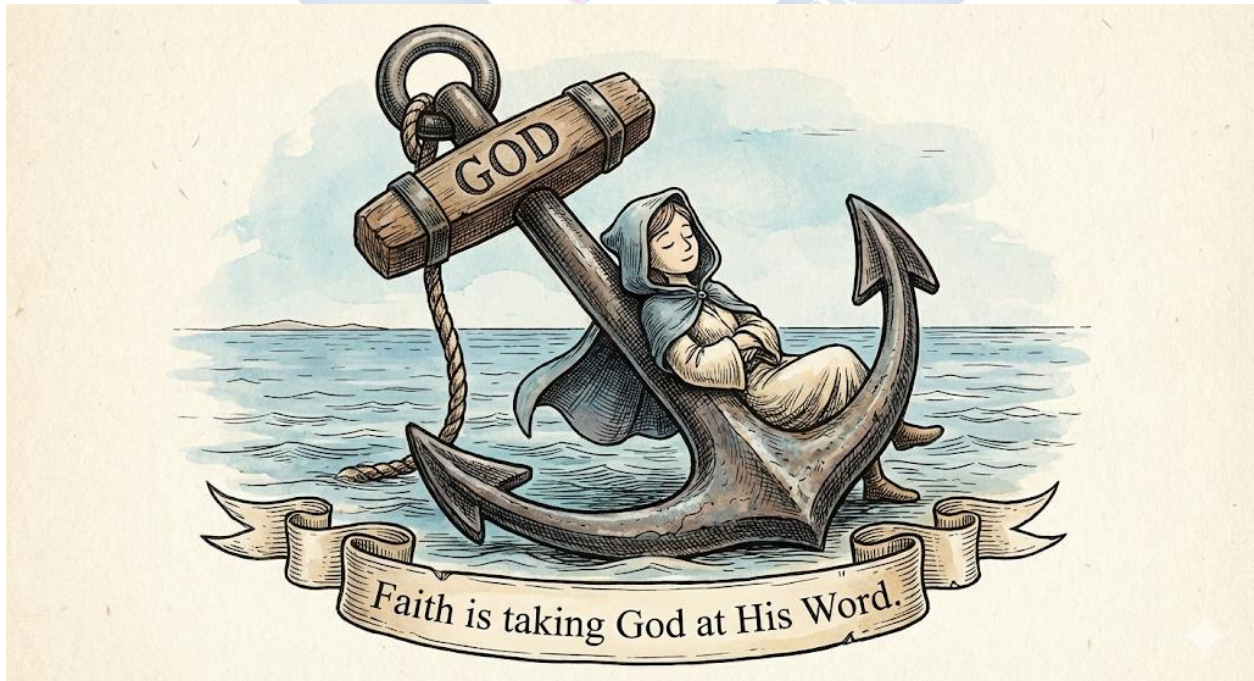
Lesson Objectives:

By the end of this lesson, students should be able to:

1. Define faith and trust in the context of a relationship with God.
 2. Narrate the story of Daniel in the lions' den.
 3. Analyse the lessons from Daniel's faith and courage.
 4. Apply the principles of faith to modern-day challenges.
-

PART 1: UNDERSTANDING FAITH

What is Faith? Faith and trust are interchangeable. It is a **firm confidence in God's ability, power, and goodness**, even in the midst of unfavorable situations. True faith means abandoning self-reliance, pride, and fear, and placing our complete trust in God.



PART 2: FAITH AND POWER (DANIEL 6:1-28)

The Setting: Daniel was a Jewish exile who rose to become one of the three top presidents in the Persian Empire under King Darius. His exceptional character and ability made him the king's favorite.

The Plot:

1. **Jealousy:** The other officials, jealous of Daniel, plotted to destroy him. They could find no fault in his conduct, so they attacked his faith.
2. **The Trap:** They tricked King Darius into signing a law that for 30 days, anyone who prayed to any god or man other than the king would be thrown into a den of lions.
3. **The Test of Faith:** Daniel learned of the decree. His response was one of **courageous consistency**. He went home, knelt by his open window facing Jerusalem, and prayed to God **three times a day, as was his custom**. He did not hide his faith.

The Consequence:

1. The officials reported Daniel to the king. Darius was distressed but bound by his own unchangeable law.
2. With a heavy heart, the king gave the order, telling Daniel, "May your God, whom you serve continually, rescue you!" (Daniel 6:16).
3. Daniel was thrown into the lions' den, and the entrance was sealed.

The Deliverance: God sent an angel to shut the mouths of the lions. Daniel emerged unharmed the next morning, declaring, "My God sent his angel, and he shut the mouths of the lions" (Daniel 6:22).

The Outcome:

- King Darius was overjoyed and ordered Daniel's accusers and their families to be thrown to the lions, where they were instantly killed.
- The king issued a new decree that all in his kingdom should "fear and reverence the God of Daniel" (Daniel 6:26).

LESSONS TO LEARN FROM DANIEL'S FAITH

1. **God is our Ultimate Protector:** God delivers those who put their absolute trust in Him. Deliverance may not always be from death, but God is always with us in our trials.
 2. **Integrity Attracts both Favor and Opposition:** Daniel's excellent spirit earned him the king's favor but also the envy of his peers. Living righteously does not make us immune to trouble.
 3. **False Accusations Will Fail:** Those who scheme against the righteous will ultimately face the consequences of their own actions.
 4. **Faith is Contagious:** Daniel's unwavering faith led a powerful king to acknowledge the one true God. Our faithful stand can positively influence those around us.
 5. **Faith Requires Consistent Action:** Daniel's faith wasn't just a belief; it was a daily practice. He prayed consistently, even when it was dangerous.
-

EVALUATION

1. Narrate the story of Daniel in the lions' den, highlighting the role faith played in the outcome.
 2. What two suggestions will you give to a present-day religious leader who faces opposition in his work of evangelism?
 3. Describe the accusation brought against Daniel. Why were his enemies unable to find any other fault in him?
 4. "Our faith in God can effect a change on others." Using Daniel as an example, explain this statement.
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WEEK 9: TRUE RELIGION AND SOCIAL JUSTICE (The Book of Amos)

Lesson Objectives:

By the end of this lesson, students should be able to:

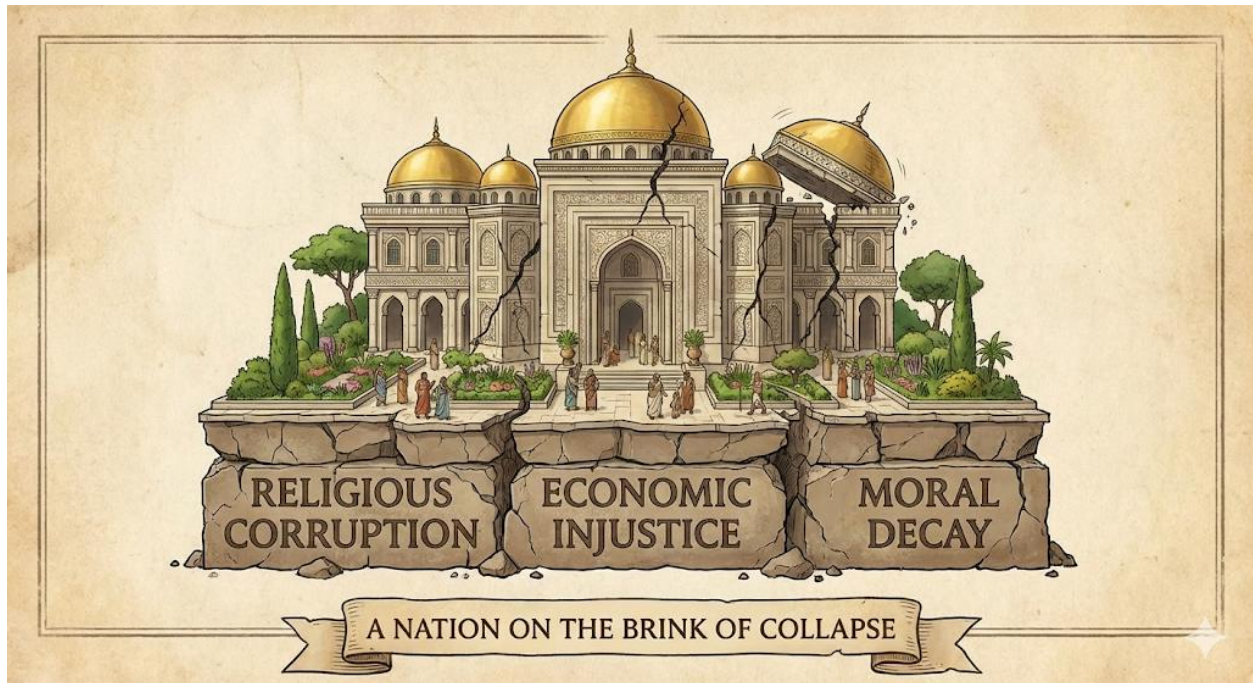
1. Analyze the socio-religious context of Israel during Amos's prophecy.
 2. Differentiate between empty ritualism and true religion as defined by God.
 3. Categorize and explain the specific social injustices condemned by Amos.
 4. Evaluate the significance of the confrontation between Amos and Amaziah.
 5. Synthesize the teachings of Amos and apply them to contemporary societal issues.
-

PART 1: THE PROPHET AND HIS CONTEXT

Who was Amos? Amos was not a professional prophet. He introduces himself as a "herdsman and a dresser of sycamore figs" (Amos 7:14). He was from the southern kingdom of Judah but was called by God to deliver a message to the northern kingdom of Israel. This makes his message particularly powerful; he was an outsider with divine authority, unafraid of the political and religious establishment.

The Historical Setting: Amos prophesied during a time of great peace and prosperity for Israel (under King Jeroboam II, circa 786-746 BC). However, this prosperity was superficial. Beneath the surface, society was rotting from within due to:

- **Religious Syncretism:** The pure worship of Yahweh was polluted. King Jeroboam I had set up golden calves in Bethel and Dan to keep people from worshipping in Jerusalem (1 Kings 12:26-30). This mixed the worship of God with pagan practices.
- **Economic Inequality:** A massive wealth gap existed. The rich lived in extreme luxury ("beds of ivory," Amos 6:4) while the poor were exploited and oppressed.
- **Moral Decay:** Justice was for sale, and the vulnerable had no protector.



PART 2: THE NATURE OF TRUE RELIGION (Amos 5:21-24)

God, through Amos, delivers a scathing rejection of Israel's worship. Their festivals, offerings, and songs were not just ignored; they were *hated* by God. Why?

- **The Disconnect:** Their worship was a performance, disconnected from their daily lives. They sang praises on the Sabbath but exploited the poor on Monday.
- **The Heart of the Matter:** God is not fooled by ritual. He looks at the heart and the actions that flow from it. Their rituals were meaningless because their hearts were filled with greed and injustice.

Key Passage: Amos 5:24

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

This metaphor teaches us:

- **Justice should be a powerful, unstoppable force** (like a mighty river).
- **Righteousness should be constant and life-giving** (like an ever-flowing stream), not occasional or seasonal.

PART 3: A CATALOGUE OF SOCIAL INJUSTICES

Amos details the specific sins that have provoked God's judgment:

Social Sin	Biblical Reference	Description in Amos's Time	Modern Parallel
Perverted Justice	Amos 2:6-7; 5:12	Judges accepted bribes to convict the innocent and deny the poor their rights.	"Cash-and-carry" justice where the rich can buy favorable rulings.
Economic Exploitation	Amos 8:4-6	Using false scales to cheat the poor, selling contaminated goods, and exploiting debt.	Selling fake products, predatory lending, and corporate greed.
Heartless Oppression	Amos 2:8	Taking a poor person's cloak as collateral for a loan and refusing to return it, violating God's law (Exodus 22:26-27).	A loan shark seizing a family's only means of livelihood.
Luxury & Apathy	Amos 4:1; 6:4-6	The elite (the "cows of Bashan") lived in self-indulgent luxury, oblivious to the suffering they caused.	Extravagant spending by politicians and elites while citizens lack basic amenities.

PART 4: CONFRONTATION & CONSEQUENCE

The Opposition: Amos vs. Amaziah (Amos 7:10-17) Amos's message threatened the status quo. Amaziah, the priest of the royal sanctuary at Bethel, accused Amos of **conspiracy** and told him to flee to Judah and never prophesy in Israel again.

Amos's Powerful Response:

1. **He Asserted His Calling:** "I was no prophet, nor a prophet's son... but the LORD took me..." (Amos 7:14-15). His authority came from God, not from a religious institution.
2. **He Pronounced Judgment:** He prophesied a specific, personal judgment against Amaziah: his wife would be violated, his children killed, and he would die in a foreign land—a direct consequence of his rejection of God's word.

The Divine Punishment for Israel: Amos warned that God's patience had run out. The punishment would be:

- **Exile:** They would be conquered and deported by Assyria.
 - **The Silence of God:** A "famine... of hearing the words of the LORD" (Amos 8:11).
 - **The Futility of Wealth:** The lavish homes and vineyards of the rich would be destroyed or enjoyed by others.
-

EVALUATION & DISCUSSION

1. **Critical Analysis:** Why did God reject the worship and sacrifices of the Israelites in the time of Amos, despite their meticulous ritual observance?
 2. **Comparative Study:** Create a detailed table comparing three social injustices condemned by Amos with their direct modern-day equivalents in our society.
 3. **Narrative Response:** "I am neither a prophet nor a prophet's son..." Narrate the events that led to this statement. What does this reveal about the source of true spiritual authority?
 4. **Personal Application:** If Prophet Amos were to visit our nation today, what three issues do you think he would address most forcefully? Justify your choices with reasoning.
-

WEEK 10: THE BAPTISM AND TEMPTATION OF JESUS CHRIST

Lesson Objectives:

By the end of this lesson, students should be able to:

1. Explain the theological significance of Jesus's baptism and its connection to Christian identity.
 2. Analyze the three temptations of Jesus, identifying their core challenges and His response.
 3. Synthesize the practical strategies Jesus used to overcome temptation.
 4. Apply the lessons from Jesus's baptism and temptation to the Christian life today.
-

PART 1: THE BAPTISM OF JESUS - A DIVINE AFFIRMATION (Matthew 3:13-17)

The Setting: John the Baptist was preaching a "baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins" (Mark 1:4). Jesus, the sinless Son of God, comes to be baptized. This creates a theological puzzle that Matthew alone addresses directly.

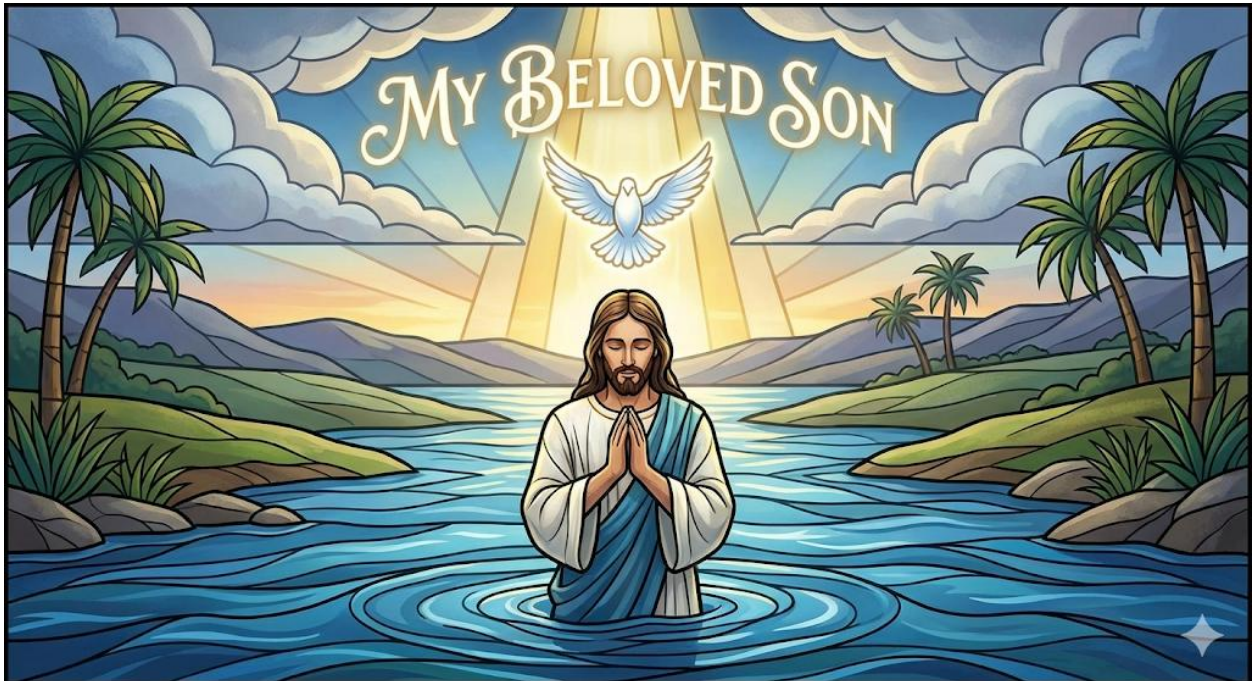
The Dialogue: John hesitates, stating, "I need to be baptized by you, and do you come to me?" Jesus' profound reply is: **"Let it be so now; for thus it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness."**

What does "fulfill all righteousness" mean?

- **Identification with Sinners:** Jesus aligned Himself completely with the sinful humanity He came to save. He didn't need repentance, but He fully entered the human condition.
- **Commissioning for Ministry:** His baptism was an inaugural act, a public dedication to His Messianic mission.
- **A Model for Believers:** He affirmed the path of obedience and set an example for all who would follow Him.

The Trinitarian Revelation: As Jesus emerges from the water, the heavens open, and:

5. **The Spirit** descends like a dove, anointing and empowering Him for ministry.
6. **The Father's Voice** declares, "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased."



This moment reveals the Holy Trinity in action and affirms Jesus's unique identity and mission.

PART 2: THE TEMPTATION OF JESUS - THE BATTLE FOR MESSIAHSHIP

(Matthew 4:1-11)

After His baptism, Jesus is led by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil. The temptations were a direct assault on His identity as the Son of God and the nature of His mission.

The Threefold Temptation: A Deeper Look

Temptation	The Lure	The Deeper Challenge	Jesus's Response & Weapon
1. Stones to Bread (Physical Need)	To use His divine power for personal comfort and to satisfy an immediate,	To be a Materialistic Messiah , who prioritizes physical	"Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that

Temptation	The Lure	The Deeper Challenge	Jesus's Response & Weapon
	legitimate need (hunger).	provision over spiritual obedience.	comes from the mouth of God." (Deut. 8:3)
2. Pinnacle of the Temple (Pride & Presumption)	To perform a spectacular, miraculous sign to force God's protection and gain a following through sensationalism.	To be a Wonder-Working Messiah , who tests God and demands proof of His care.	"You shall not put the Lord your God to the test." (Deut. 6:16)
3. Kingdoms of the World (Power)	To achieve worldwide power and authority instantly, bypassing the suffering of the cross.	To be a Political Messiah , who gains the world by worshipping Satan (compromising with evil).	"Be gone, Satan!... You shall worship the Lord your God and him only shall you serve." (Deut. 6:13)

Key Strategy: In every temptation, Jesus countered Satan's lies with the truth of **Scripture**. He did not argue; He declared God's Word.

PART 3: SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY APPLICATION

Why was Jesus's Temptation Significant?

- **He is Our Sympathetic High Priest:** "For because he himself has suffered when tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted" (Hebrews 2:18).
- **He Reversed the Failure of Adam:** Where Adam failed in a perfect environment, Jesus succeeded in a barren wilderness, demonstrating His power as the perfect Son of God.
- **He Defined True Discipleship:** His path was one of obedience, suffering, and service, not of comfort, spectacle, or political power.

Overcoming Temptation Today: A Practical Guide

1. **Know Your Identity in Christ:** The devil's first words were, "If you are the Son of God..." Temptation often begins with a challenge to our identity as God's children.
 2. **Be Rooted in Scripture:** We cannot use the "sword of the Spirit" (Ephesians 6:17) if we do not know it.
 3. **Recognize the Counterfeits:** Temptation is often a good thing (bread, safety, power) offered at the wrong time, in the wrong way, or by the wrong source.
 4. **Submit to God and Resist:** Jesus's final command, "Be gone, Satan!" (James 4:7), shows the authority we have in Him.
-

EVALUATION & DISCUSSION

1. **Theological Explanation:** "Thus it is fitting to fulfill all righteousness." Explain the meaning and significance of this statement by Jesus at His baptism.
2. **Comparative Analysis:** Create a table that outlines the three temptations of Jesus, detailing the nature of each temptation, the scripture Jesus used to counter it, and a modern-day example of a similar temptation a Christian might face.
3. **Reflective Response:** From the account of Jesus's temptation, what three key strategies can a Christian employ when facing their own temptations? Provide a biblical basis for each strategy.
4. **Synthesis Question:** How does the baptism of Jesus establish His identity and mission, and how does His temptation immediately afterward reinforce the *nature* of that mission?

SS 2 CHRISTIAN RELIGIOUS STUDIES LESSON NOTES

THIRD TERM

- 1 Call of the Disciples
 - 2 The Mission of the Disciples (Luke 10:1-24)
 - 3 The Trial of Jesus Christ and his Death
 - 4 Resurrection and Second Coming of Jesus Christ
 - 5 Midterm Examination
 - 6 Fellowship in The Early Church
 - 7 Midterm Break
 - 8 The Holy Spirit and the Mission of the Gentiles
 - 9 Opposition to The Gospel Message I
 - 10 Opposition to The Gospel Message II
- 

WEEK 1 – CALL OF THE DISCIPLES

Jesus calls the first four disciples (Matthew 4:18-22; Mark 1:14-20; Luke 5:1-11)

Jesus went to the shore of Lake Genesaret to preach the gospel. He went aboard a boat and pushed out a little from the shore, where the audiences stood facing him. He sat down and taught the people from the boat.

When he finished teaching, he asked Simon, who owns the boat, to push out his net into the deep water for the catch. Simon replied that he and his companion had worked all night and caught nothing but at Jesus' word, he would let down the net.

And when Peter did, they caught an enormous shoal of fish. It was so big that their nets began to tear. Thus, they signaled their partners, James and John, the sons of Zebedee, in the other boat, to come and help them. They came and both boats were filled to a sinking point.

Simon was so surprised that he fell at the feet of Jesus and asked Jesus to depart away from him because he, Peter, was a sinful man. Jesus told him that he should not be afraid, adding that Simon will now be catching men. Simon and his partners brought their boats ashore. They left everything and followed Jesus. The others were Andrew, James and John.

The call of the twelve Disciples/Apostles (Mark 3:13-19) Jesus selects His disciples (Matt 4:18-22; 9:9, Mark 3:13-19)

Jesus chose twelve disciples to be with him and to assist him in preaching the gospel. He called them one by one and told them that he would make them fishers of men. They immediately left their jobs and followed him. Some of them were fishermen, while some were tax collectors. Four of them were referred to as member of the inner circle. This is because they were especially close to him. They were Simon Peter, Matthew, James and John sons of Zebedee.

When Jesus was on a mountain, he called the men of his choice after healing some people in Galilee. Out of these men, he selected twelve as his immediate companions and friends. These he wanted to send out to proclaim his message, the gospel, with the authority to drive out demons and heal all kinds of diseases.

The Twelve Disciples:

- Simon Peter
- James
- John
- Simon the Canaanites
- Andrew
- Philip
- Bartholomew
- Thomas
- Thaddeus
- Matthew
- James the son of Alphaeus
- Judas Iscariot, who betrayed him

They all willingly responded to the call of the master without excuse, the most important qualification Jesus sought for was willingness and self-denial. We learn a lesson here to be obedient to the call of God.

These twelve were to be his messengers, who will carry the message of Christ to all parts of the world and to all people. In the Acts of the Apostles, these disciples were referred to as apostles. After the death of Judas, following his betrayal of Jesus, Matthias was elected as the twelfth apostle.

The Demands of Discipleship (Luke 9:57-63; 14:25-33)

To be a disciple of Jesus has its demands and obligations. Jesus' encounter with three would-be disciples shows the cost of being a disciple of Jesus.

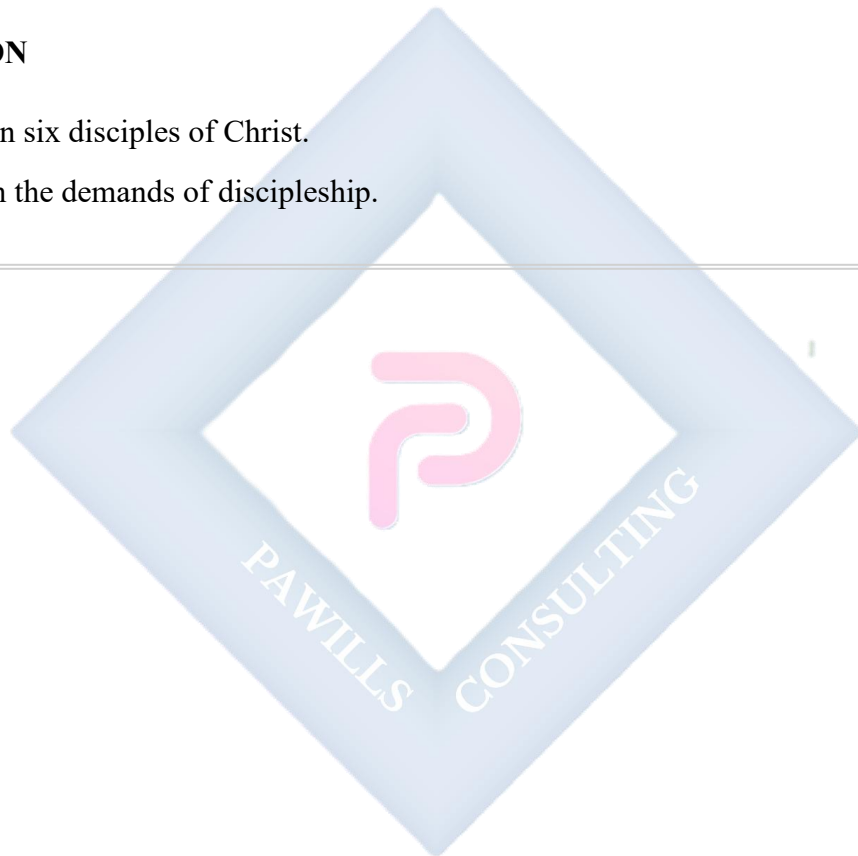
To the one who voluntarily told Jesus would follow him, Jesus told him that birds and foxes have holes but he, the son of man, had no home. Another one who decided to follow him asked for a time to say farewell to his relations. Jesus told him that anyone who put his hands on the plough

and look back was not fit for the Kingdom. The one whom he invited to follow him requested to be allowed to go and bury his father. Jesus told him to let the dead bury the dead.

There was a time many people were following Jesus. He turned and told them that any would-be follower who did not love him more than his father, mother, wife, children, family and even his own self could not be his disciple. Jesus concluded that no one could be his disciple, unless he or she was ready to give up everything he or she had.

EVALUATION

1. Mention six disciples of Christ.
 2. Explain the demands of discipleship.
-



WEEK 2 – THE MISSION OF THE DISCIPLES (LUKE 10:1-24)

The mission of the Twelve (Mark 6:7–13)

Jesus called the disciples to him and gave them their mission. He gave them the authority and power to heal the sick and cast out evil spirits. Jesus sent the disciples out in pairs to carry on his work. They travelled in pairs for protection on the road, and so that others would believe events had occurred because they were witnessed by another disciple.

The disciples were given instructions to travel light on their journeys and to rely on the kindness of those who took them in. They were to stay in the first house that welcomed them until they left that town. This meant that they would have to learn to depend on God for everything that they needed.

Jesus anticipated that the disciples would face rejection and criticism. He instructed them to shake the dust from their feet as they left if they faced rejection in a town. Jews would have routinely completed this action when leaving a Gentile area. In this case, a Jew would be doing this action to a fellow Jew – showing how serious it was to have rejected God.

Mission of the Seventy

Sometime after the mission of the twelve, Jesus sent out another batch of seventy disciples to win more souls for God. This was because there were many, many souls to be saved but few disciples to do the work. Therefore, Jesus said to them: “The harvest is plentiful, but the labourers are few”

Jesus said the seventy should pray to the Lord of the harvest to send more labourers into his harvest. He was sending them out as lambs in the midst of wolves. They should carry no purse, no bag, no sandals, and greet no one on the road. When they enter a house they should pray: “Peace be to this house.”

If a peaceful person was in the house, the peace would stay, if not it shall return to them. They should not go from house to house, but remain in the one house eating food and drinking what is given to them.

When they enter a town and they were well received, they should eat the food given to them, and heal the sick among them and say: “The kingdom of God has come near to you.” But if they were rejected by a town, they should go outside and say: “Even the dust of your town that cling to our feet, we wipe off against you; nevertheless know this that the kingdom of God has come near you.”

Jesus said it would be more tolerable for Sodom and Gomorrah than any town that rejected them. Jesus then pronounced woes (judgement) on the chief cities in Galilee where most of his mighty works were performed because they did not repent: “Woe to you, Chorazin! Woe to you, Bethsaida! For if the mighty works done in you had been done in Tyre and Sidon, they would have repented long ago, sitting in sackcloth and ashes. But it shall be more tolerable in the judgement for Tyre and Sidon, than for you. And you Capernaum, will you be exalted to heaven? You shall be brought down to Hades.”

Jesus ended the charge to the seventy disciples by saying: “He who hears you hears me, and he, who rejects you, rejects me, and he who rejects me, rejects he who sent me.”

Significance of the Mission: The mission of the seventy signifies Jesus's mission to the Gentiles (non-Jewish people). It demonstrates the power and authority given to believers to preach, heal, and cast out demons in Jesus's name. It highlights the importance of prayer, reliance on God, and hospitality in Christian ministry.

Outcome of the Mission of the Twelve and Seventy Two The two missions were successful in the following way:

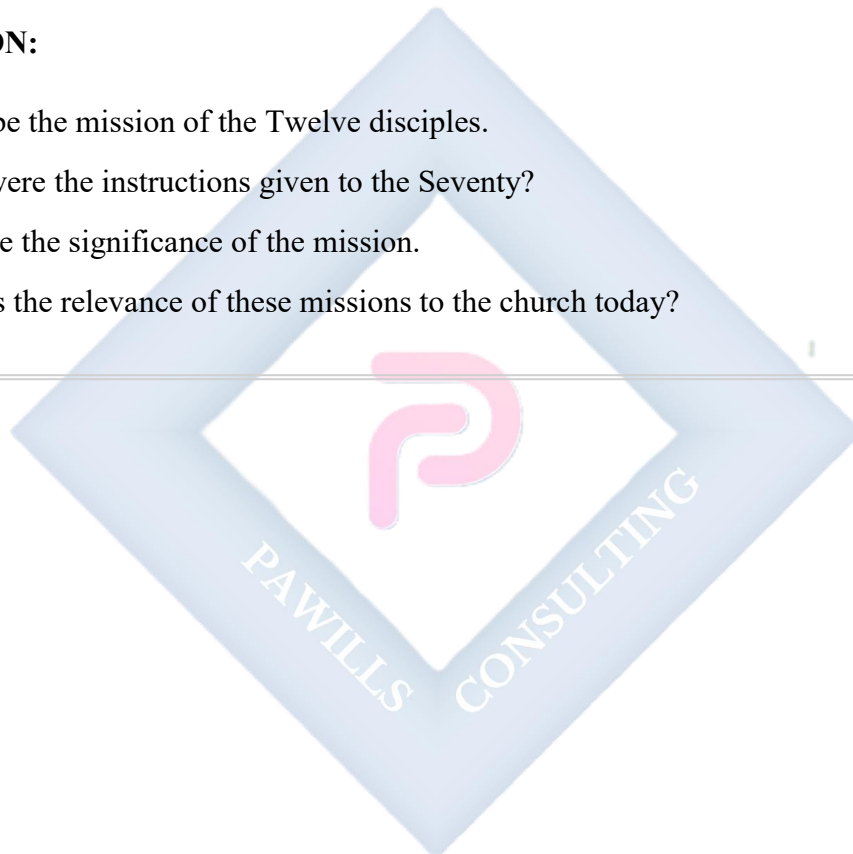
1. The twelve apostles and the seventy two disciples healed the sick and cured them of their diseases.
2. The seventy particularly came back rejoicing that the devils submitted to them at the mention of Jesus name. Jesus himself confirmed it by saying that he saw demons fall like lightening from heaven.
3. He assured them that he has given them power to tread upon serpents and scorpions and all the power of the enemy. He said that nothing shall ever hurt them.
4. He cautioned them not to rejoice because of their achievements but to rejoice because their names were written in heaven.

Effect of the Disciples' Activities on Nigerian Christians.

1. In order to spread the words of God in all parts of the world, we must embark on evangelism now. We can do it like the disciples did.
 2. It made us understand that we should not focus on material gain when embarking on evangelism.
 3. If we have strong faith in Christ, we can do the work of evangelism.
-

EVALUATION:

1. Describe the mission of the Twelve disciples.
 2. What were the instructions given to the Seventy?
 3. Analyze the significance of the mission.
 4. What is the relevance of these missions to the church today?
-



WEEK 3 – THE TRIAL OF JESUS CHRIST AND HIS DEATH

THE TRIAL OF JESUS CHRIST

Trials is define “as examinations of evidence in law court by a judge and often a jury to decide if one accused of a crime is innocent.” Jesus Christ underwent several trials in the course of His ministry when He was betrayed by Judas Iscariot. He was tried by the High Priest (Sanhedrin), Pontius Pilate, King Herod and back to Pontius Pilate.

Christ Before The High Priest

After the arrest of Jesus in the garden of Gethsemane by the people Judas Iscariot brought, He was taken into the court room of the High Priest Caiaphas where He was tried by the High Priest in company of the Elders and Scribes. Two persons were brought who presented false charges against Jesus claiming He said He would destroy the temple in three days and rebuild it again in three days, which was considered as blasphemy.

The High Priest asked Jesus to defend Himself of the charges leveled against Him but Jesus kept quiet. He was then asked if He was the Christ, the son of God, to which he responded “You have said so” implying that he was indeed the Christ, the son of God. At this point, the High Priest said Jesus had committed Blasphemy punishable by death under the Jewish law. The people answered that Jesus deserve to die. They spat on His face, struck and slapped Him and requested him to prophesy to them who had slapped Him.

Meanwhile Peter, one of His disciples that followed Him into the courtyard of the High Priest was being confronted by maids and bystanders as one of Jesus’ disciples, to which Peter denied three times. Immediately the cock crewed the second time, Peter remembered that he had being warned by Jesus earlier of his denial of Christ. Peter went out and wept bitterly.

The next day, Jesus was brought before the Council of Elders, the Chief Priest and the Scribes. It was here that Jesus was formally condemned to death but was sent to Pontius Pilate the Roman governor for approval since they have no such powers.

Christ Before Pilate

After the trial of Jesus by the High Priest and Jewish authorities not having the authority to carry out capital punishment for blasphemy, the charge brought against Jesus and condemning Him to death, sent Him to Pilate but with the following charges knowing full well that Pilate was more interested in political than religious charges that: Jesus was a seditious agitator perverting the nation, Jesus was inciting people against tax payment. Jesus claim to be king of the Jews, thereby overthrowing Caesar.

Pilate asked Jesus if was the king of the Jews and He answered 'thou have said so'. The Chief Priest announced the other two accusations, to which Jesus refused to answer. Pilate was surprised at this. Having discovered that Jesus was accused out of envy, Pilate tried to set Him free. Moreover his wife (Pilate) sent a message to him "saying have nothing to do with that righteous man, for I have suffered a greatly over him today in a dream" but the Jews demanded the release of Barabbas and the condemnation of Jesus.

Seeing that the people might revolt if he do otherwise and since he did not want a rebellion by the people moreover the whole event took place during the feast of Passover (holy period), he therefore washed his hands publicly declaring that he will not be guilty of Jesus' blood, all the people declared "His blood be upon us and our children. "He released Barabbas to them and having Jesus' flogged, he delivered Him to be crucified. The soldiers of Pilate took Jesus to the Praetorium and gathered the battalion, stripped him and put a scarlet cloth on him. They also plaited a crown of thorns and placed it on His head, as well as reed on His hand. They mocked Him by kneeling down before Him, hailing Him as the king of the Jews. They spat on Him and took the clothes and led Him out for crucifixion.

Christ Before Herod

When Pilate heard that Jesus was from Galilee and under King Herod's jurisdiction, he sent Jesus to Herod who was then in Jerusalem, having not found Jesus guilty of any charge. Herod was happy to see Jesus having heard much about Him without seeing Him in person. He expected Jesus to perform some miracle in his presence. Herod questioned Jesus for a long time over the accusations brought against Him by the Chief Priests and Scribes (rulers of the law) Jesus however did not answer him a word. Herod and his soldiers mocked Jesus, dressed Him in

an expensive robe and sent Him back to Pilate. This action of Herod restored the broken relationship between Herod and Pilate, thus they became friends again.

The Crucifixion and Burial of Jesus

The soldiers took Jesus away and put a purple cloth on Him. They tortured Him by putting a crown of thorns on his head. They mocked Him by saluting Him: “Hail King of the Jews”. They beat Him and spat upon Him. After maltreating Him, they took away the purple cloth and led Him away to be crucified. On the way they met Simon of Cyrene who was forced to help Jesus carry the heavy cross. Simon helped Him, till they came to Golgotha, the place of crucifixion.

At Golgotha, the soldiers gave Jesus wine mixed with gall (a concoction) to drink. But when He tested it, He didn't like it and so He refused to drink it. The concoction was meant to reduce the pain that He might suffer after He had been nailed to the cross. The soldiers crucified Jesus by laying Him on the cross and hammering nails into his hands and feet. Jesus suffered as the nails pierced his flesh. They then shared his sleeveless garment among them by casting lot. Then on the top of the cross they put the charge for which Jesus was crucified: “This is Jesus the King of the Jews.” Two robbers were crucified with Jesus, one on his right side and the other on his left. The crowd mocked Him to save Himself from the cross, if He was the Christ. The Chief Priests also mocked Jesus as He hung on the cross saying He saved others but could not save Himself. One of the two robbers also said bad things about Jesus.

The Death of Jesus: Matt 27: 45- 56

When it was noon, there was darkness all over the land till three O' clock in the afternoon. Jesus then cried with aloud voice: “Eloi, Eloi, lama sabacthani!” which means: “My God, My God, why hast thou forsaken me?” Some of the people thought He was calling on Elijah to come and save Him. Immediately, the curtain of the Temple was torn into two and Jesus cried with aloud voice: “Father, into thy hands I commits my spirit”. When the soldiers saw all this, they confessed that Jesus was truly the Son of God.

The women disciples of Jesus, including Mary Magdalene, Mary, the mother of James and Joseph, and the mother of the sons of Zebedee were at the place of crucifixion. They sympathized with Jesus and cried and wailed when Jesus died on the cross.

The Seven Words of Jesus on the Cross

1. Woman, behold, your son, Son, behold your mother.
2. Father forgive them, for they know not what they do.
3. Truly I say to you, today you will be with me in paradise
4. I thirst.
5. Eloi, Eloi, lama sabachtani: which means My God, My God, why hast thou forsaken me.
6. It is finished
7. Father into thy hands I commit my spirit.

The Burial of Jesus

In the evening, Joseph from Arimathea, a respected member of the Council/Sanhedrin. He was a friend and secret disciple of Christ, a good and righteous man who was after the Kingdom of God. He was aware that it was against Jewish custom to have a dead body on the cross overnight. He approached Pilate and asked for the body of Jesus to go and bury it. Pilate, been sure of Jesus' death, released the body. He wanted to bury Jesus because the next day was Sabbath. Joseph took Jesus' body from the cross and wrapped him in a linen shroud. He then laid the body in his own rock tomb and secured the entrance with a big stone. The women disciples were there to see where Jesus was buried.

The Significance of Jesus Death on the Cross

1. The death of Christ on the cross is mainly for the salvation of mankind.
2. It is by his death that Christians are saved. Jesus paid the supreme sacrifice for salvation.
3. The perishable and mortal body of man must die. Death is inevitable.
4. We should forgive those who wrong us just as Jesus forgave those that crucified him.
5. Jesus' words on the cross signify that his death was God's plan to save humanity.
6. As Christians, we should be able to sacrifice something for the growth of Christianity, just like Joseph of Arimathea who buried Jesus in his personal grave.
7. The events that took place at his death confirm his son ship.

EVALUATION

1. Outline the stages of Jesus' trial.
2. Describe the events that took place during Jesus' crucifixion.
3. Why is Jesus' death significant to Christians?
4. Mention one role each of Pilate and Herod played in Jesus' trial.
5. Who buried Jesus, and where?



WEEK 4 – RESURRECTION AND SECOND COMING OF JESUS CHRIST

The Resurrection (Matthew 28:1 – 8, Mark 16:1 – 6, Luke 24:1 – 11)

Resurrection means coming back to life after death. The resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead was to show his victory over death. The account of the resurrection appears in all three synoptic gospels. They all stated that when the women disciples-Mary Magdalene, Mary, mother of James and Salome went to the tomb to embalm the body of Jesus, they discovered that he had resurrected.

Matthew reported that there was a great earthquake; angel of the Lord descended from heaven and rolled back the stone and sat upon it. It was this angel that informed the women that Jesus had risen from the dead. However, Luke and Mark did not report any earthquake. Mark reported that as the women were contemplating who would help them roll away the stone at the entrance of the tomb, they saw a young man sitting at the right side dressed in a white robe and they were amazed. He told them: “Do not be amazed; you seek Jesus of Nazareth who was crucified. He has risen, he is not here; see the place where they laid him” (Mark 16:6). The angel then directed them to go and inform his disciples to prepare themselves and meet him in Galilee. Mark added that the women left the tomb trembling and astonished and they could not say anything to anybody.

Luke’s account was similar to that of Mark except that he added that as the women were perplexed over what happened to the body of Jesus, two men stood by them in dazzling apparel. It was these men that informed them of the resurrection of Jesus. When the women told the news to the disciples, they did not believe them.

The Significance of the Resurrection of Jesus Christ

- i. The resurrection of Jesus Christ is the basis of Christian faith. Without his resurrection, there would be no Christian faith.
- ii. God raised Jesus from the dead thereby confirming him as His son.
- iii. Resurrection equally forms the basis of Christian hope of salvation.

- iv. It is an assurance that as God raised Jesus from the dead, so will God raise every Christian that die in the Lord on the day of resurrection.
- v. Again, the resurrection of Jesus and the hope that the Lord we are serving is alive and this is Christian's hope of eternal life in the kingdom of God which is in Christ.
- vi. It was the resurrection of Jesus from the grave that helped to encourage the early apostles to preach the gospel with boldness. The fulfillment of all that Jesus had promised gave the disciples and early apostles much confidence and trust in him.

The Second Coming of Christ

The second coming of the Lord Jesus Christ is the expectation of many Christians based on the teachings of Jesus Christ after his resurrection and the ascension, he would go and prepare a place or spiritual home for the children of God and he would later return and rapture them.

Signs of the Second Coming of the Lord (1 Thess. 4:13 – 18, 2 Thess. 2:1 – 12) St. Paul in his epistle to the Thessalonians described the signs of the second coming of Jesus Christ and showed how it would involve the living and the dead. He also showed some of the preparations that Christians should make for his second coming through good conduct and righteousness.

Paul started by first of all giving warnings to the Thessalonians that they should not be deceived by word or letter purported to have come from him, for the second coming would not come unless the rebellion comes first and the man of lawlessness is revealed, the son of perdition, who opposes and exalts himself against every so called God or object of worship, so that he takes his seat in the temple of God, proclaiming himself to be God. The mystery of lawlessness is already at work although it is yet to be revealed. The lawlessness one will operate with the power of Satan and produce pretended signs and wonders with all wicked deception for those who are to perish because they refuse to love the truth and be saved. Therefore, God will send upon them a strange delusion to make them believe what is false so that all who do not believe the truth, but have pleasure in unrighteousness will be condemned. Paul said the appointed time, the lawless one would be revealed, only to be destroyed by Christ's breath.

St. Paul further warned the Thessalonians not to be grieved for those who are dead in the Lord as he declared: "But we would not have you ignorant; brethren, concerning those who are asleep,

that you may not grieve as others do who have no hope. For since we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so, through Jesus, God will bring with Him those who have fallen asleep. For this we declare to you by the word of the Lord, that we who are alive, who are left until the coming of the Lord, shall not precede those who have fallen asleep. For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with the cry of command with the archangels' call and with the sound of trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first, then we who are alive who are left shall be caught up together with them in the cloud to meet the Lord in the air, so we shall always be with the Lord. Therefore, comfort one another with these words" (1 Thess. 4:13 – 18). Thessalonians embraced the doctrine of the second coming of Jesus Christ with all their minds and they thought it was going to be immediate. So, they were afraid of their brethren who died before the resurrection and the second coming of the Lord. But Paul made it clear to them that as long as you are in Christ, death cannot separate the person from him. As Jesus resurrected from death so will they be raised up again.

Paul went further to outline the signs of the second coming as;

- i. Christ will descend from heaven with a cry of command with archangels' call and with the sound of the trumpet of God.
- ii. The dead in Christ will rise first; then those who are alive shall be with them in the clouds (in their spiritual bodies) to meet the Lord and remain with Christ forever.
- iii. There will be certain destruction for the unwary. He finally told the Thessalonians to comfort one another with these words.

Preparation for His Second Coming (1 Thess. 5:1 – 11)

St. Paul said it was needless to write about the time and season. The point is that Christians should get ready, for the day of the Lord will be sudden like a thief in the night. St. Paul warned Christians not to relent in their efforts, thinking that they have peace and security, for in such deceptive situation, destruction would come suddenly upon them like travail of a woman in labour. Therefore, whoever that does not anticipate the second coming or is not conscious of it, will certainly be caught unawares. The message is that true Christians, we dead or living, have hope of salvation. All the living Christians need to do is to be prepared by living a righteous life with strong faith in the redemption work of Jesus Christ.

Significance/ Lessons to Learn

- i. Christians should live in readiness, knowing fully well that the second coming of Jesus is a reality.
 - ii. Christians should watch and pray, study their Bibles always and observe their fasting.
 - iii. They should live obedient and righteous lives.
 - iv. Christians should engage in evangelism and preach to others about the reality of the second coming of Jesus Christ.
 - v. Christians should not grieve much about their brethren who died for they would rise again on the resurrection day.
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EVALUATION

- i. Describe the second coming of the Lord, according to Paul's teaching. What does this teach us as Christians?
 - ii. What are the signs of the second coming of Jesus Christ?
 - iii. What kind of preparation should Christians make for the second coming of the Lord?
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WEEK 6 – FELLOWSHIP IN THE EARLY CHURCH

Communal Living In The Early Church (Acts 1:15 – 26; 2:41 – 47; 5:1 – 11; 6:1 – 6)

After Christ ascension, the apostles and the disciples about one hundred and twenty of them together. Peter addressed them on the need to find a replacement for Judas Iscariot who had committed suicide following his betrayal to Jesus Christ. Peter mentioned some of the attributes of the person to be elected as one of the original disciples of Jesus Christ by John the Baptist, and all his earthly ministries, resurrection and ascension and should preach the gospel and take care of the needs of the Christian community.

Based on these qualifications, the disciples forwarded two names – Barnabas and Mathias. The congregation prayed for God’s guidance in choosing the right person. After prayers, they cast lots and the lots fell on Mathias and he was then registered with the eleven apostles.

Lessons to Learn From The Election Of Mathias

- i. The prayer, the casting of lots and the eventual election of Mathias shows that God was behind the election.
- ii. Consideration should be given to character and qualities of person to be elected into positions.
- iii. People to be elected into positions of authority in the church should be experienced and faithful Christians who live their lives according to the word of God.

Problems of the Early Christian Community and their Solutions (Acts 5:1 – 22; 6:1 – 6)

As it is common in every society, the communal life and fellowship among the early Christians were destroyed by dishonesty and discrimination, this was quickly stopped by the apostles.

Ananias and Sapphira

As many of the Christians sold their property and brought the proceeds to the congregation, it was assured that any member of the congregation that sold his property should follow the same trend, though; people were not forced to sell their properties. Ananias and Sapphira, in order to enjoy the same praise given to others who had sold their property and brought the whole

proceeds, went and sold their own property. But rather than bring the whole proceeds, they kept back some and brought some of it to you the congregation.

Peter rebuked them sharply for dishonesty, saying; ‘Ananias why has Satan filled your heart to lie to the Holy Spirit and to keep back part of the proceeds of the land? While it remained unsold, did it not remain your own? After it was sold, was it not at your disposal? How is it that you have contrived this deed in your heart? You have not lied to men but into God (Acts 5:3 –

4).Immediately Ananias received this rebuke, he fell down and died. The young men around carried him away and buried him. The whole congregation was afraid at what happened. When Sapphira, Ananias’s wife who did not know what happened arrived, Peter also asked her whether all what the husband brought was the proceeds of the land. She confirmed that it was all. Peter equally rebuked her and she fell down and died.

Significance and Lessons To Learn

- i. Lying by these couple resulted into their death. Christians therefore should learn how to be faithful to God in all their dealings. God is a consuming fire. The consequence of telling lies may be disastrous.
- ii. When people are honest with God and their fellow human beings, the result is blessing. So Christians should endeavour to be honest.
- iii. Ananias and Sapphira were misguided into thinking that they could serve both God and Mammon at the same time.

Discrimination and Favouritism In The Early Church (Acts 6:1 – 6)

The early Church was made up of the Hebrews, Greeks and people from other nations of the world. Problems arose when the non-Jews accused the Jews of neglecting their widows in the daily distribution of food that was donated by the wealthy members of the church. The apostles therefore summoned a meeting of the elders of the community and explained: “It is not right that we should preach the word of God and serve tables. Therefore, brethren pick out from among you seven men of good repute, full of the spirit and wisdom, whom we may appoint to this duty. But we devote ourselves to prayer and to the ministry of the word.” (Acts 6:2 – 4).Based on this,

seven deacons were chosen from the congregation. The seven deacons included: Stephen, Phillip, Prochorus, Nicanor, Timon, Parmenas and Nicholas.

Problems Of The Present Day Church As the early Church had social problems, the present day church is also faced with problem or the other. These problems include; i. There is always struggle for leadership in most of all the churches. This coupled with ethnic problems, have led to splitting of churches. ii. Some church leaders, due to lust for materialism have departed from the faith. For this reason, they desist from preaching sound doctrines and are now preaching prosperity and materialism without holiness. Whereas the Bible says without holiness, no man can see God. iv. Again, some pastors live immoral life, thereby making people deviate from the doctrine they preach.

EVALUATION:

- i. What social problems brought about the appointment of the deacons in the early Church? Mention five social problems facing the church today.
 - ii. Trace the events that led to the election of Mathias as one of the twelve. Highlight three problems that should be borne in mind when conducting election.
 - iii. Describe the election of the successor of Judas Iscariot. What two lessons can be learnt from this incident?
 - iv. What led to the selection of Mathias as one of the apostles? How was the selection conducted?
 - v. Trace the circumstances that led to the death of Ananias and Sapphira. Indicate two lessons that could be drawn from this incident.
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WEEK 8 – THE HOLY SPIRIT AND THE MISSION OF THE GENTILES

The Ascension (Acts 1:6 – 11)

The Ascension in the context of the scripture simply describes the manner in which Jesus Christ was taken into heaven. After his last appearance, he was with the apostles in Jerusalem. They asked him about the time the Lord would restore the kingdom of Israel. Jesus made them realize that God himself is the only one who knows the time and then season, not human beings.

The Important thing is that they would receive power and after that the Holy Spirit would come upon them. They would be witnesses to him in Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria and the uttermost part of the world. When he finished the address, he was taken up to heaven. As the apostles were gazing up to heaven, two men in white robes said to them: “Men of Galilee, why do you stand looking into heaven? This Jesus who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven.” (Acts 1:11).

Significance

- i. The ascension indicated that Jesus would no longer be with the disciples in the flesh (physically) but in the spirit. As Christ departed, the Holy Spirit was sent to take leadership positions in the life of believers. For Christians, it is the Holy Spirit that would give them guidance and courage in evangelism and other works of God.

The Holy Spirit At Pentecost (Acts 2:1 – 41)

The word Pentecost is a Greek word for fifty. For the Jews, the Pentecost was another name for the feast of weeks. This feast was celebrated fifty days from the Passover feast. It was one of the three main feasts of the Jews, during Pentecost; every male child must appear before the Lord. It was an agricultural feast to mark the completion of wheat during which they gave thanks and praise to God who made it possible for the crops to grow and the fruits ripen. They would then use the occasion to welcome the new year of agriculture.

It was on this Pentecost day the apostles received the gift of the Holy Spirit. They were all with one accord in one place, when a sound from heaven like a rushing mighty wind filled the house where they gathered. There appeared on their head, tongues as fire which sat upon each of them.

They were all filled with the Holy Spirit and they started speaking in other tongues as the spirit gave them utterances.

There were many pilgrims from different nations of the world in Jerusalem that day. They converged together to listen to the apostles but they were amazed as each heard the apostles speak in his own language. While many of the multitude wondered on, some mocked them, saying they were already drunk. Peter stood up and refuted the charge of drunkenness. He said they were not drunk as the people had thought, but they were speaking in tongues in line with the out pouring of the Holy Spirit as prophesied by Joel that, on the last day He would pour His Spirit upon all flesh, people would prophesy and there would be signs and wonders. He further recounted the signs and wonders God had accomplished through Jesus Christ and his crucifixion and resurrection.

To support the resurrection of Jesus, Peter quoted the Psalm of David which says, “For thou will not abandon my soul to Hades nor let the Holy one see corruption. “Peter said David was speaking about the resurrection of Christ that he would not be abandoned to Hades; that his flesh would not see corruption. Peter said the people were witnesses to the resurrection of Jesus Christ.

As Peter concluded his speech, the people listening to him were touched and they inquired from him what they should do. Peter advised them to repent from their sin and be baptized for the forgiveness of their sins. About three thousand people repented at the Pentecost and they were all baptized. They joined the disciples and received the Holy Spirit.

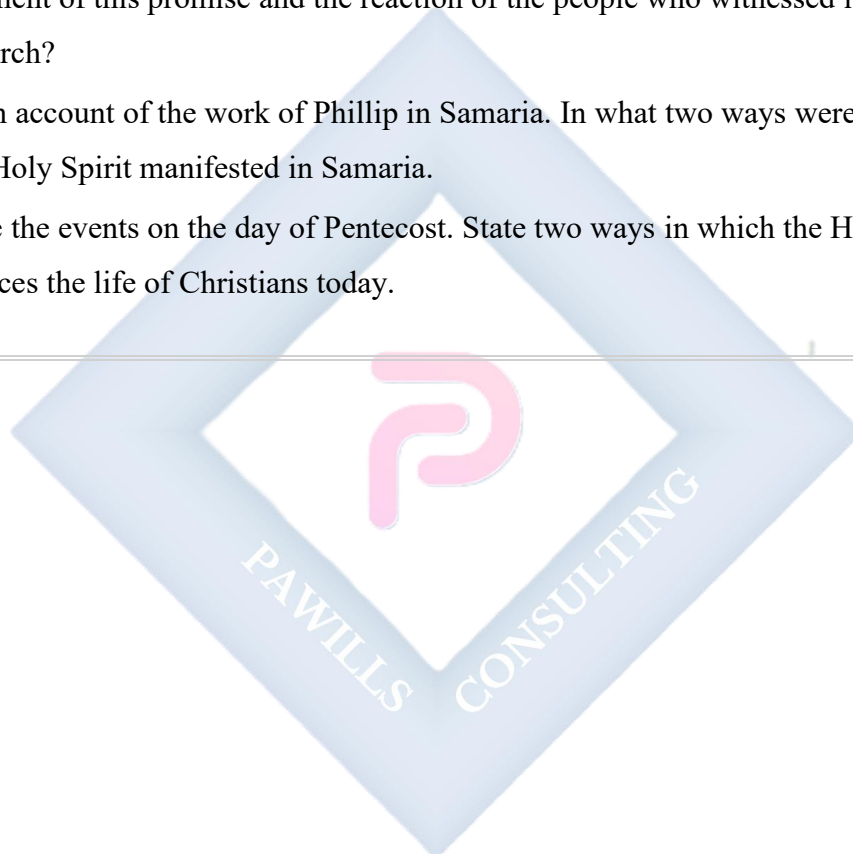
The Significance of the Descent of the Holy Spirit

- i. Prior to the Pentecost day, the apostles were afraid; it was receiving the Holy Spirit that day of Pentecost that gave them the courage and boldness to preach the gospel.
- ii. The miracle whereby the apostles spoke in tongues and the nations of the world around understood their languages symbolizes the universalism of the gospel.
- iii. The Pentecost marked the beginning of evangelism as that was the day the apostles started preaching the gospel and after Peter concluded his speech, about three thousand would were won for Christ.

- iv. The coming of the Holy Spirit marked the beginning of the Christian Church and the continued presence of Jesus among the disciples and believers. Jesus is continually active in all the churches who serve God in truth and in spirit.
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EVALUATION

1. “You shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you”. Discuss the: (a) Fulfillment of this promise and the reaction of the people who witnessed it. Holy Spirit to the church?
 2. Give an account of the work of Phillip in Samaria. In what two ways were the activities of the Holy Spirit manifested in Samaria.
 3. Narrate the events on the day of Pentecost. State two ways in which the Holy Spirit still influences the life of Christians today.
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WEEK 9 & 10 – OPPOSITION TO THE GOSPEL MESSAGE (ACTS 4:1 – 31; 5:17 – 42; 6:8 – 15; 9:1 – 3; 12:1 – 24)

Opposition to the Gospel Message (Acts 4:1 – 31; 5:17 – 42; 6:8 – 15; 9:1 – 3; 12:1 – 24)

After the death, resurrection and ascension of Jesus Christ, attempts by the apostles to spread the gospel met with stiff resistance from the Jewish religious authorities, the chief priests and the Sanhedrin. Some of the techniques employed by these people to frustrate the spread of the gospel included arrest, fake trials, imprisonment, persecution and killing. Some of these wicked techniques were used in dealing with the apostles, but the more they tried to stop them, the more the apostles succeeded until Christianity was established all over the world.

The Arrest of Peter and John (Acts 4:1 – 31)

After Peter and John healed the lame man at the temple gate, the people gathered in amazement and Peter and John preached to them in the name of Jesus. This teaching annoyed the priest, the captain of the temple and the Sadducees because the apostles were teaching the people, proclaiming Jesus' resurrection from the dead. For this reason, they arrested them and put them in custody.

The following day the elders, the scribes, Annas the high priest, Caiaphas, Alexander and all the high-priestly family gathered and brought Peter and John in their midst to try them. They asked for the source of the power with which they did what they had done. Peter filled with the Holy Spirit, defended their action and declared that they performed the miracles through the power in the name of Jesus Christ whom they had crucified but whom God raised from the dead. He referred to Jesus as the stone which – they the builders rejected but has become the head of the corner. Only through him the salvation of man is assured, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved.

When they saw the boldness of Peter and John, they wondered greatly because they noted that though the disciples were uneducated and common men, they had been with Jesus Christ. The authorities saw that the man who Peter and John had healed was standing there with them, so they did nothing against them. They ordered them out so that they can confer with one another.

They finally decided to charge the men not to speak in the name of Jesus anymore so as to prevent further spreading of Christianity among the people.

When John and Peter were told this, they responded by asking them whether it was right in the sight of God to listen to them or God. The authorities further threatened them and then released them. Peter and John afterwards reported the incident to the church. The congregation prayed to God for more strength and power to face the opposition from the authorities. After the prayer, they were filled with the Holy Spirit and they preached the gospel with boldness and more signs were done by them.

Significance The arrest of Peter and John was prompted by the commotion that came as a result of healing the man who was lame. Peter's address equally disturbed the worship in the temple. Because the captain of the temple was responsible for maintaining law and order in the temple, he had to arrest Peter and John. Again, the Sadducees did not believe in resurrection, they believe that the teaching of the apostles contradicted their belief and, as such, they felt threatened.

The Arrest and Trial of the Apostles (Acts 5:17 – 42)

As the apostles continued to spread the gospel by the power of the Holy Spirit, the high priest and his men got the apostles arrested and put them in prison out of jealousy. There, in the prison the angel of the Lord released them and said to them, "Go and stand in the temple and speak to the people all the words of His life". The apostles did exactly as the angel directed them.

When the Sanhedrin met, they sent for the apostles in prison but they were not there. Later, an informant told them that the apostles were in the temple, preaching. Because of the people in the temple, they were brought gently without violence. When the men were brought to the Sanhedrin, the high priest questioned them saying: "We strictly charged you not to teach in this name, yet here you have filled Jerusalem with your teaching and you intend to bring this man's blood upon us".

Peter and the apostles replied: "We must obey God rather than men. That God our Father raised Jesus whom you killed by hanging him on a tree. God exalted him at his right hand as leader and savior, to give repentance to Israel and forgiveness of sins. And we witness to these things, and so is the Holy Spirit whom God has given to those who obey him." (Acts 5:30 – 32)

The response of the apostles enraged them and they wanted to kill the apostles. A Pharisee in the council, Gamaliel, a teacher of the law held in honour of our people, stood up and ordered them to be put outside for a while. Then he advised; “Men of Israel, take care what you do with these men. For before these days, Theudas arose, giving himself out to be somebody and a number of men, about four hundred joined him; but he was slain and all who follows him were dispersed and come to nothing. After him, Judas the Galilean arose in the days of Census and drew away some of the people after him; he also perished and all who followed him scattered. So, in the present case, I tell you, keep away from these men and let them alone, for if this plan or undertaking is of men it will fail; but if it is of God, you will not be able to over throw them; you might even be found opposing God’ (Acts 5:35 – 39). The council took to his advice. When they called in the men, they beat them and before they left them, they warned them not to speak in the same of Jesus again. The apostles left the presence of the council, rejoicing that they were counted to suffer dishonour for the name of Jesus.

Qualities Attributable to Gamaliel i. Gamaliel was a man of courage. He did not display any fear in his efforts to protect the apostles. ii. He proved himself an educated man with good knowledge of history. iii. He was a godly man who did not believe in wickedness and did not want the murder of innocent apostles.

Significance and Lessons to Learn The arrest of the twelve apostles was one of the greatest threats to the Christian faith, but God, through the power of the Holy Spirit, gave the apostles the power to defend themselves. God also used Gamaliel to intervene on their behalf. If the twelve disciples had been killed, this probably would have been the end of Christian faith, but God did not allow it. This is also a lesson to Christians that in the time of difficulty, the Holy Spirit always helped in all ways to ensure that they are set free from such difficulty.

Different Types of Opposition confronting the Church Today i. In some parts of the country and even in some schools, Christians are not allowed to preach publicly. ii. Also, church buildings are not allowed in some parts of the country. iii. Christians suffer open persecution thereby leading to wanton destruction of lives and property.

The Death of Stephen (Acts 6:8 – 15; 7:1 – 60)

Stephen was one of the seven deacons selected to carry out the daily distribution of food and ensure the welfare of the less privileged people in the early church. Stephen was full of grace and power, he performed great wonders and signs among the people. Some of the Jews could not withstand the wisdom and the spirit with which he spoke. Consequently, these men secretly incited men who brought false accusations against him. The accusations were as follows; i. That he blasphemed against Moses, the law and God, ii. That he claimed Jesus would destroy the temple. These accusations by Jewish law constituted serious offence punishable by death.

When Stephen was arraigned before the council, he surprised them by failing to refute the allegation. He decided to trace the history of the Jews to show that they had been noted for persecuting the prophets of God. He referred to them as stiff-necked people, uncircumcised I'm heart and ears. This statement angered the people the more. Based on this, they dragged him outside the city and stoned him to death.

Significance and Lessons to Learn

- i. Stephen was killed based on false accusations. Therefore, present day evangelists should know that the same fate awaits them at all times. They should therefore pray always for God's guidance and protection.
- ii. The successful arrest, trial and killing of Stephen encouraged the Jews embark on mass persecution of the Christians and, consequently, many of them were killed, but that did not stop the spreading of the gospel.
- iii. Persecution is part of the heritage of Christians and they should not be encouraged by such things; rather persecution should make them strong in their faith.
- iv. The stoning of Stephen helped to introduce Saul who later became Paul the apostle to the Gentiles.

Saul's Opposition to the Gospel (Acts 9:1 – 2)

Saul was a young man born in Tarsus. He was educated in Jerusalem and he studied law under the great teacher, Gamaliel. The Roman name of Saul was Paul. He was among the Pharisees who persecuted the early Christians, Stephen was killed under his supervision. After the death of Stephen, he went from house to house in Jerusalem arresting and dragging Christians out of their

homes and taking them prisoners. Thus, Saul succeeded in killing many Christians. Most of the Christians fled from Jerusalem and went to places such as Judea, Samaria and Damascus among others. Saul went to the high priest and obtained a letter to go to Damascus and arrest the Christians.

Significance and Lessons to Learn i. Saul engaged in the persecution of the Christians because he was ignorant of the gospel. He thought he was working for God, but when his eyes were opened, he understood the gospel and became more zealous than the apostles. Many people today are in this category. Due to their ignorance, they engage in criticism and gossips against the children of God. People should be very careful of what they do and what they say, particularly when they do not understand it very well. ii. God arrested Saul's spirit and converted him, God is ever ready to accept anybody, regardless of his atrocities, once he has changed and confessed. Christians should endeavour to leave their bad ways and turn unto God.

Herod's Persecution of the Christians (Acts 12:1 – 24)

Herod Agrippa was very violent in his opposition to the gospel. The Herods were not Jews, but were appointed by the Roman Empire to rule the Jews and the Jews did not like their system of leadership. The Herods therefore did everything possible to win the confidence of the Jews. When Herod Agrippa realized that the Jewish council was opposed to the spread of the church, he joined in the persecution of the Christians just to please the Jews.

When he killed James the brother of John, he discovered that it pleased the Jews who hated the Christians. He then proceeded to arrest Peter. Herod put Peter in prison, waiting for feast of unleavened bread and the Passover to pass before he could kill him. The night before the day Herod planned to kill Peter, Peter was sleeping bound between two soldiers. The angel of the Lord appeared to Peter and said, "Dress yourself and put on your sandals." And he obeyed. The angel also commanded him to wrap his mantle and follow him. Peter followed the angel through the first gate and when they came to the iron-gate leading to the city; it opened without any effort by them. They went out and immediately, the angel left him. All this while, Peter thought he was seeing vision and it was after the angel left him that he realized it was the angel of the Lord that came to rescue him. Peter then went straight to Mary's house where some Christians had gathered to pray for him.

When Herod could not understand the mystery behind Peter's escape from prison, he was furious that he executed the prison guards. Later, Herod himself was killed by the angel of God because he refused to glorify God for the gift of oration. He was eaten up by worms and the word of God continued to grow and multiply.

Significance and Lessons to Learn

- i. It is very important to note that it was the stiff opposition the early Christians faced that acted as the necessary ingredient in the spread of the gospel.
 - ii. The boldness and the courage of the Christians then was enhanced by the Holy Spirit.
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EVALUATION

1. How did God use Gamaliel to further the cause of Christianity in the early Church?
2. Mention any four type of opposition that are confronting the Christian Church today.
3. What were the charges against Stephen?